



A BEGINNER'S GUIDE TO BRAZILIAN JIU JITSU

MARC BARTON

**GET A HEAD START ON YOUR
JIU JITSU JOURNEY**

A Beginner's Guide to Brazilian Jiu Jitsu

by

Marc Barton

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Second edition

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Introduction

Welcome to Brazilian Jiu Jitsu.

If you have just started, well done. You have taken the first step into something that can genuinely change your life.

I don't say that lightly. Jiu Jitsu has changed my life completely. It gave me direction, focus, and a community I didn't even know I was missing. It tests you, frustrates you, and sometimes completely humbles you. But it also gives back more than almost anything else I've ever done.

When I first stepped on the mat, I didn't have a clue what I was doing. I was thirty, unfit, and not exactly built for grappling. But I loved it straight away. I think most people do. There's something addictive about the honesty of it. You can't fake progress in Jiu Jitsu. You either keep improving or you don't. And that's what makes it so powerful.

Jiu Jitsu began in Brazil in the early 1900s, developed by the Gracie family. The idea behind it is simple. Use timing, balance, and leverage so that a smaller person can overcome a bigger one. It is about technique, not brute strength. That's why it works for everyone. You don't need to be young, flexible or particularly athletic. You just need patience and a bit of stubbornness.

In class, you will learn how to escape, sweep, control, and submit. You will figure out how to stay calm when someone is on top of you and everything in your body wants to panic. You will get used to feeling lost. We all do at first. But if you keep showing up, little by little, it starts to make sense.

It is often said that out of a thousand people who start Jiu Jitsu, only a handful ever make it to black belt. Most quit somewhere along the way. Usually, it is not

because they can't do it. It is because they expect it to get easier sooner. The truth is, it never really gets easy. You just get better at dealing with the hard bits.

If you can accept that, you will be fine. You will get fitter, stronger, and more confident. You will learn how to handle pressure, both on and off the mat. You will make great friends. And you will probably end up enjoying yourself more than you thought you would.

This guide will walk you through the basics. What to expect. How to survive those early weeks. How to train smart and build a foundation that lasts.

Whether you're completely new or coming from another martial art, my hope is that it helps you find your footing and keeps you moving forward.

Welcome to the journey. I'm genuinely glad you're here.

Enjoy the training,

Marc

Chapter 1: I Was the Worst Guy in the Room

When I first started Jiu Jitsu, I had no idea what I was getting into. I thought it might be a good way to get fit, maybe learn a few self-defence skills. I didn't expect it to change the direction of my life.

It did, though. Completely.

Jiu Jitsu gave me a new direction, a new purpose, and eventually, a completely different life. In 2014, I walked away from my job as an Emergency Medicine doctor to teach Jiu Jitsu full-time. That decision shaped everything that followed. But if you had told me that back when I started, I'd have laughed in disbelief.

Because when I began, I was terrible. Truly. The worst guy in the room.

This was back around 2006, when I first joined the beginners' classes at the old Roger Gracie Academy on Kensal Road. That place had something special about it. The smell hit you as soon as you walked in – part sweat, part mat cleaner, part something else that's hard to describe. It smelled like effort. Like a place where people were trying to become better versions of themselves.

Everyone looked fitter, faster, and stronger than I did. I was thirty, which at the time felt ancient to be starting something so physical. These days, thankfully, you see people of all ages stepping onto the mats, but back then, it felt unusual. I'd watch the younger guys move easily through techniques while I struggled to keep up, trying to remember which leg went where.

I'd get crushed. Every session. I'd tap from top pressure, forget half the moves, and leave drenched, demoralised and exhausted. Some nights, I'd drive home in silence, wondering if I was just wasting my time. But something in me refused to stop. I came back anyway.

That became my secret. Not speed, not strength, not flexibility. Just persistence.

No matter how bad the last session went, I'd be there for the next one. Through injuries, through night shifts, through the exhaustion of a young family – I kept training.

Progress was slow. Painfully slow at times. But every so often, I'd notice something had shifted. I'd survive a round a little longer. Escape from someone who used to tap me easily. Remember a detail that suddenly made sense. It didn't feel like progress most days, but it was happening, quietly, under the surface.



Jiu Jitsu was a struggle for me in the early days (I'm sat against the wall exhausted between rounds as a blue belt here in 2009)

And then one day, I realised I was standing near the top of the beginners' lineup. Most of the people I'd started with were gone. Life had pulled them away, as it does. But I was still there. Somehow, still coming back.

That's when I started to understand what Jiu Jitsu really teaches you. It is not about being the most talented person on the mat. It is about being the one who stays. The one who trains on the days they don't feel like it.

The belts came slowly. White to blue. Blue to purple. Then brown. And, after ten years of steady work, black.

Years later, I was having a coffee with one of my instructors from those early days – someone you’d definitely recognise if I named him (but I won’t). We were talking about those first few years – how tough they’d been, how many people had come and gone. He smiled and said something that made me laugh out loud.

He told me that if he’d had to pick anyone from that first room who would make it to black belt, I would have been the last person on his list.

I took that as one of the biggest compliments I’ve ever received. Because he was right. I wasn’t built for it. I wasn’t particularly strong or athletic. I didn’t pick things up quickly. But I kept going.

It is funny how that works. You look back after a decade and realise that talent doesn’t matter nearly as much as you thought. The gifted ones often disappear first. The ones who quietly persist – the tortoises in the race – they are the ones who last. If you’re reading this and feeling like the slowest learner in class, you’re not alone. Everyone starts there. Every black belt you will ever meet knows that feeling of being crushed, confused, and completely out of their depth.

The only thing you have to do is keep training. That’s all.

Don’t worry about how long it takes. Don’t compare yourself to anyone else. Some weeks you will feel great, others you will question everything. But keep coming back anyway. The lessons you can’t see are the ones that eventually change you.

And one day, you will look around and realise you’re still there when most of the people you started with aren’t. You will be the one who outlasted them. You will have your own stories, your own scars, maybe even a few students who look at you the way you once looked at your coaches.

That’s the real magic of Jiu Jitsu. It doesn’t reward talent. It rewards persistence.

It rewards the ones who stay.

Chapter 2: The History of Brazilian Jiu Jitsu

Today Brazilian Jiu Jitsu is one of the world's fastest-growing and most popular combat sports. The number of people training is growing exponentially. It is recognised not only as one of the most effective martial arts but also as having immense benefits for both physical and mental health. But how did we arrive here, and what are the origins and history of this martial art that we love so much?

What exactly is 'Jiu Jitsu'?

The term Jiu Jitsu is derived from the Japanese 'ju', which means gentle, soft or flexible, and 'jutsu', which means art or technique. For this reason, many people refer to Jiu Jitsu as the gentle art. Jiu Jitsu is the spelling used in Portuguese, whereas ju jutsu is a more direct phonetic translation of the Japanese words. Nowadays, 'ju jutsu' tends to refer to the original Japanese art, whereas 'Jiu Jitsu' tends to refer to the derivative Brazilian art. For ease and consistency, I will use the spelling 'Jiu Jitsu' throughout this article.

Modern Brazilian Jiu Jitsu is predominantly a grappling martial art with a particular emphasis on ground fighting techniques that use leverage and timing to achieve a submission on the opponent using joint manipulation and chokes.

Forged on the battlefields of feudal Japan

The roots of all modern martial arts can be traced back thousands of years to Buddhist monks in southwest India, from where they spread to China, Okinawa and mainland Japan. The story of modern Jiu Jitsu, however, starts on feudal Japan's battlefields. It is believed that Jiu Jitsu was initially developed as the fighting art of the samurai. The samurai were heavily armed and armoured on horseback. Their armour restricted their movements significantly and made the martial arts used in

neighbouring Okinawa and China, which mainly utilised striking techniques, ineffective. A system of fighting that focused more on throws, joint locks, and chokes was developed to enable the samurai to defend themselves and fight effectively if they found themselves disarmed and on foot. The oldest recorded style of formally taught Jiu Jitsu is Shinden Fudo-Ryu, founded around 1130 CE by Ganpachiro Temeyoshi.

Jiu Jitsu would evolve further in the 17th century during the Tokugawa shogunate when laws influenced by neo-Confucianism were imposed to reduce war. The civil wars of the Sengoku period came to an end, and a new era of stability emerged. Unarmed combat gained popularity during this period, and the practice of Jiu Jitsu became more widespread throughout society. By the early 1800s, there were hundreds and possibly even thousands of different schools of Jiu-Jitsu, each with its own unique flavour and style, being taught in Japan.



A studio photograph of a Samurai in typical armour, taken by Felice Beato circa 1860 ([public domain photo](#))

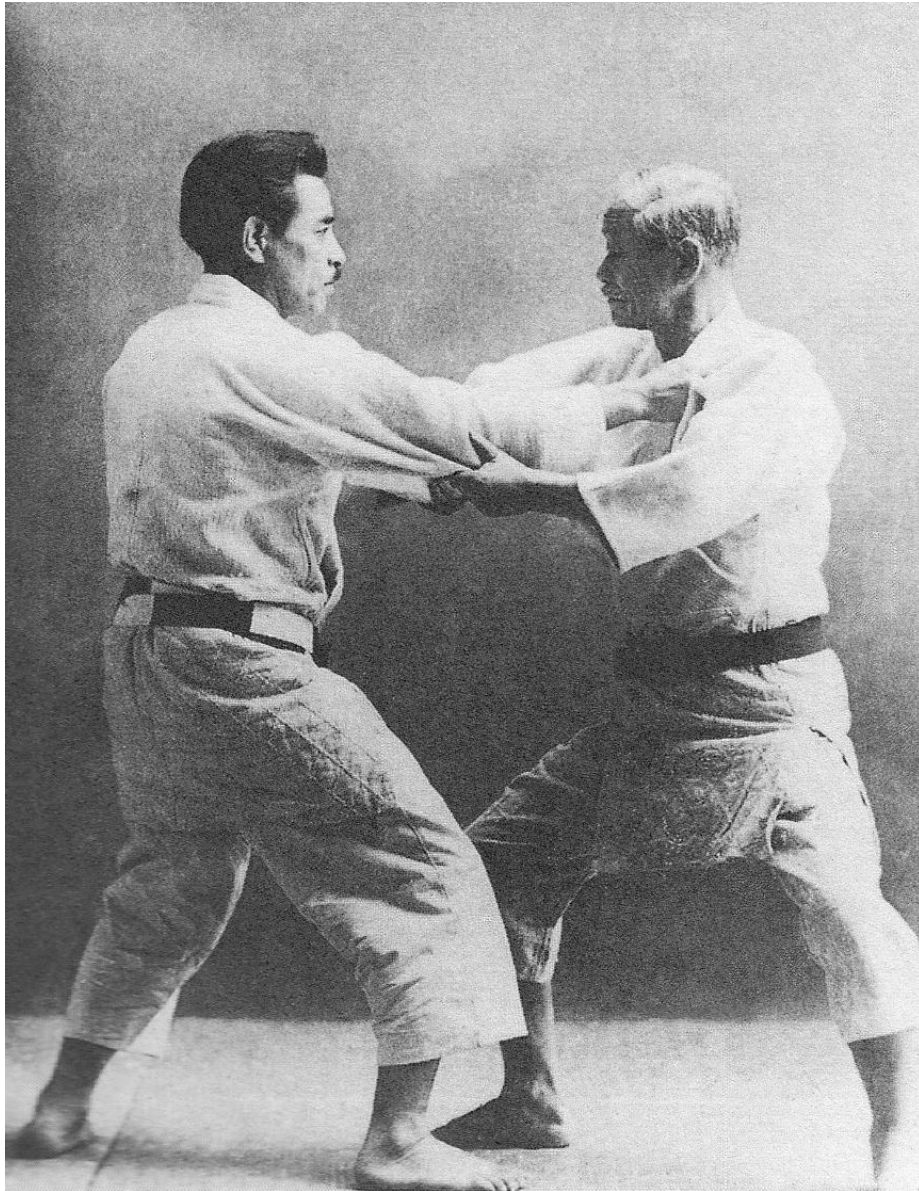
The vision of Jigoro Kano and a new art

In 1874, a young student at an English-medium school in Tokyo began searching for a dojo where he could study Jiu Jitsu as a means of self-defence due to the awful culture of bullying that was endemic at the school. Unfortunately, during the second half of the 19th century, Jiu Jitsu became less popular as Japan became increasingly Westernised, and Kano struggled to find a school where he could train.

It would take him until 1877 to find a willing teacher, Fukuda Hachinosuke, who taught the Tenjin Shin'yo-ryu style of Jiu Jitsu. Fukuda died in 1880, and Kano continued his study of Jiu Jitsu at another nearby school under the tutelage of Iso Masatoma. Iso, however, also died in 1881, causing Kano to move to yet another school; this time, he would train in the Kito-ryu style of Jiu Jitsu under Iikubo Tsunetoshi. In 1882, Kano opened his own school and dojo at the Eisho-Ji Buddhist temple in Tokyo. In 1883, he was promoted to the rank of Menkyo by Iikubo Tsunetoshi, an official teaching grade, who supported him by regularly visiting his dojo. It was not long before Kano began defeating Iikubo.

Kano named his school the Kodokan Judo Institute, with Judo meaning 'the way of gentleness'. Kano's Judo style combined the various styles and teachings of Jiu Jitsu he had been exposed to, and added his own discoveries and ideas. Kano was an educator by profession, and he also managed to create a standardised syllabus of throws, newaza ground fighting techniques and kata with a heavy emphasis on randori sparring. He also introduced the teaching of Judo into schools.

The Kodokan began with fewer than a dozen students in 1882, but grew steadily and had to relocate several times to accommodate the increasing number of students who flocked to train there. By the time of Kano's death in 1934, the Kodokan had expanded to a 510-mat facility with thousands of students.



Jigoro Kano training with his student Kyuzo Mifune sometime in the 1930s
([public domain photo](#))

From Japan to Brazil

The first time Jiu Jitsu instructors arrived in Brazil is believed to have been in 1909 via a bizarre set of circumstances. While on patrol in the Pacific Ocean, the Brazilian Navy cruiser Benjamin Constant caught sight of a shipwrecked crew of Japanese sailors. Among the crew they rescued were two Jiu Jitsu instructors, Sada Miyako and Mme. Kakiara. Miyako and Kakiara returned to Brazil with the crew of the Benjamin Constant and ended up staying there for some time.

Following a short stint fighting challenge matches for a travelling circus, Miyako signed a contract with the Brazilian Navy and remained with them until 1912, teaching Jiu Jitsu to seamen and the military during that time. Legend has it that Sada Miyako competed in Brazil's first-ever Vale Tudo match against a Capoeira fighter called Cyriaco Franciso da Silva, which he lost in humiliating fashion.

A couple of years later, in 1914, another Japanese instructor, Mitsuyo Maeda, arrived in Brazil. Maeda had spent many years training in Judo at the Kodokan under one of Jigoro Kano's top students, Sakujiro Yokoyama. Maeda travelled to Brazil with four other students from the Kodokan. The group, like Miyako a few years earlier, spent time fighting challenge matches for a travelling circus.

Maeda was renowned for his ferocious newaza (ground fighting) based style of Judo. It should be noted that Maeda also still referred to Kano's style as Kodokan Jiu Jitsu, as opposed to Judo. This was commonplace at the time, and hence the reason we train in Brazilian 'Jiu Jitsu' and not Brazilian 'Judo' today.

Maeda continued travelling around Brazil for several years before finally settling in Belém in 1920. Around this time, he met and befriended a businessman and politician of Scottish descent named Gastão Gracie. Gastão helped Maeda establish a Japanese immigrant community, and as an expression of his gratitude for Gastão's assistance, he accepted his son, a teenager called Carlos Gracie, as his student.



A photograph of Mitsuyo Maeda taken in 1910
([public domain photo](#))

The Gracie family take centre stage

Over the next few years, Maeda continued to teach Carlos, and in time, Carlos would also share the art with his four brothers: Oswaldo, Gastão Jr., George, and Hélio. Hélio was smaller and weaker than his brothers and apparently had difficulty executing the judo-style techniques that had been passed down from Maeda. This led Hélio to adjust these techniques, focusing more on leverage and making them easier for smaller fighters to use successfully against larger opponents.

In 1925, the Gracie brothers, led by Carlos, opened Brazil's first Jiu Jitsu academy, and 'Gracie Jiu Jitsu' was born. Over the years that followed, the Gracie brothers continued to refine the art and regularly pressure-tested it with brutal public challenge matches, pitting themselves and their students against practitioners of other fighting arts, such as boxing, luta livre, capoeira, and luta romana.

The 1950s saw Gracie Jiu Jitsu rise to new levels of recognition, with Hélio participating in several high-profile challenge matches, including three against world-renowned Judoka. Hélio fought Yukio Kato twice in September 1951, the first bout ending in a draw, and Hélio won the second by choke. This led to the now legendary bout against the much larger Masahiko Kimura. The Gracie vs Kimura fight occurred in front of 20,000 people in the Maracanã Stadium in Rio de Janeiro. Despite fighting valiantly, Hélio lost via a gyaku-ude-garami armlock, now commonly referred to as a Kimura armlock. Despite the loss, Gracie received recognition for a spirited performance against a much physically larger opponent.



A photograph of Hélio Gracie taken in 1952
([public domain photo](#))

The next generations of the Gracie family

In the 1950s, Carlson Gracie would take up the mantle as the lead fighter in the Gracie family. Carlson was the first-born son of Carlos. Like his uncle, Carlson took part in many challenge matches and continued to raise the profile of Gracie Jiu Jitsu. Perhaps the most famous of these were his fights against the capoeira fighter Waldemar "The Black Panther" Santana. Santana had beaten Hélio in October 1955, and there was significant bad blood between Santana and the Gracie family, a former janitor at the Gracie Academy. Carlson and Santana would face off four times in high-profile fights, with Carlson winning two and the other two ending in draws.

In the 1970s, Rolls Gracie rose to prominence. Rolls was born on March 28th, 1951, the love child of Carlos Gracie and Claudia Zandomenico, a young Italian air stewardess who worked for Lufthansa and lived in Rio. Because Rolls was born out of wedlock, Carlos's wife did not want to raise him, so Carlos entrusted his brother, Hélio, to bring him up.

At this time, Gracie jiu-jitsu was mainly taught based on Helio's style of using defensive grappling to wear opponents down and then submit them. Carlson had already started to modify the art, introducing a more aggressive style better equipped to meet the challenges facing jiu-jitsu fighters in Vale Tudo. However, Rolls began incorporating new techniques he had learned from his training in other combat arts into his style of Jiu Jitsu. He was particularly impressed with the work ethic of the wrestlers and brought that same attitude to his own training. Rolls would take his students on long runs, push the pace when rolling with opponents and was very aggressive in his pursuit of submissions. He always encouraged his students to train in other arts, as he had, such as Judo, wrestling, sambo, and other grappling arts, to expand their horizons as well.

Rolls taught many notable jiu-jitsu athletes in his short time as an instructor, including Rickson Gracie, Carlos Gracie Jr, Royler Gracie, and Rigan Machado. He promoted just six men to black belt before his tragic early death in a hang-gliding accident: my instructor Mauricio Motta Gomes, Marcio Stambowsky, Romero "Jacare" Cavalcanti, Nicin Azulay, Paulo Conde and Mario Claudio Tallarico.

The Ultimate Fighting Championship changes everything

The 1970s saw Jiu Jitsu travel across the ocean again, this time to the United States. In 1972, Carley Gracie, the 11th child of Carlos Gracie, arrived there and was the first person to teach Gracie Jiu-Jitsu in the country. Six years later, the oldest son of Hélio, arrived in California and opened an academy in Los Angeles.

In an attempt to increase awareness of his family's fighting art in the United States, Rorion created the 'Gracie Challenge', an open invitation for challengers from other martial arts for an 'anything goes' match against a Gracie Jiu Jitsu student. These matches are now legendary, and many were videoed and can be watched online. These matches would also provide the inspiration for another challenge match event. Together with Art Davis, Rorion created the 'The Ultimate Fighting Championship' (UFC), which pitted fighters from various martial arts and fighting styles against each other in a tournament-style event. These events marked the beginning of the hugely popular and successful mixed martial arts (MMA) movement. Rorion chose his younger brother Royce to represent them in the inaugural event in 1993. Royce was not a big man, but despite his smaller stature, he won all of his fights by submission and was crowned as the first UFC champion. Royce would go on to win the tournament two more times, in UFC2 and UFC 4. His victories were eye-opening for many people, who realised it really was possible to defeat bigger, stronger opponents using the Gracie family's Jiu Jitsu. Another Gracie, Rickson, would take Jiu Jitsu to even higher levels in mixed martial arts. Rickson is the third oldest son of Hélio, and he would go undefeated in MMA, competing mainly in Japanese events such as the Pride Fighting Championships.

The modern era of Brazilian Jiu Jitsu

Following the success of Jiu Jitsu in the UFC and other MMA events, its popularity has steadily grown. The Gracie family style of Jiu Jitsu began to be referred to simply as 'Brazilian Jiu Jitsu' (BJJ), and more and more people started to seek out and learn this exciting martial art that was dominating other styles.

In 1996, the first-ever BJJ world championships, commonly known as the 'Mundials', took place in Rio de Janeiro. In 2002, Carlos Grace Jr. founded the International Brazilian Jiu Jitsu Federation (IBJJF), and BJJ started spreading rapidly from country to country. In 2007, the Mundials relocated to California, where they have remained ever since, and over 6,000 competitors participated in the tournament in 2022. Roger Gracie, the son of Mauricio Gomes and Reila Gracie, would dominate the sport scene in the 2000s, becoming a ten-time world champion, and many believe that he is the greatest Jiu Jitsu competitor of all time.

Jiu Jitsu continues to grow and evolve continuously, with new techniques and moves being introduced constantly. New academies are opening worldwide, and almost every large town now has at least one place to train. It has never been easier to find a place to train in this exciting martial art that started on the battlefields of Japan almost one thousand years ago.

Chapter 3: Choosing the Right Academy

If you are about to embark on your Jiu Jitsu journey, one of the most daunting tasks can be choosing where to train. Nowadays, you will almost certainly have multiple academies within travelling distance to choose from, and all of these will have their own unique feel and style of teaching.

There are numerous factors you should consider when trying to choose between these academies and committing to a place to train multiple hours per week. Below, I will highlight what I believe are the most important questions you should ask yourself when making this significant decision.

Why are you starting Jiu Jitsu?

Everyone who is starting Jiu Jitsu has their own reasons for wanting to give it a go, and it is important to take time to consider what your own personal motivation is. Some people are keen to learn a form of self-defence, others want to get fit, some aspire to compete, and some are simply looking for a fun new hobby.

When researching the different academies that are available to you, try to find out if they are a good fit for you and have the right sort of classes, curriculum and focus for you. Some academies are more self-defence orientated, while others are more heavily involved in the competition scene. Some larger academies will have a great mix of both and provide different types of classes that you can choose from.

Ensure that whichever academy you choose, your goals are well-aligned and that it can provide you with what you are looking for.

What are the head instructor and teaching team like?

So much about every Jiu Jitsu academy is determined by the head instructor and the teaching team. Try to find out as much as possible about the head instructor before committing to an academy.

Is the head instructor a black belt? As little as five years ago, it was not uncommon for academies to have a brown or even purple belt as the head instructor, but in the past few years, the number of black belts teaching has exploded, and most academies now have a black belt head instructor. This is not to say that brown and purple belts can't be great instructors, and there are many fantastic teachers of these ranks around, but the black belt is a stamp of quality, and you should be in safe hands with one. There are also degrees or ranks of black belts, and the higher the degree, the longer that instructor has been a black belt and the more experienced they will be.

What is the instructor's lineage? In Jiu Jitsu, lineage refers to who a student received their belts from, and it shows how that belt can be traced back through generations of instructors, often back to the Gracie family, the founders of Brazilian Jiu Jitsu. Verifying an instructor's lineage will ensure you receive quality training from a certified and competent black belt instructor. The instructor's lineage will often also determine what their teaching style is like and what types of techniques they will teach.

What is the instructor's personality like? So often, the head instructor's personality sets the tone and vibe of the academy. Ideally, you want the instructor to be someone who is friendly and approachable and who teaches classes that you enjoy attending.

What is the affiliation of the academy?

Most Jiu Jitsu academies are now affiliated with a parent association and/or some form of national governing body. Any academy that isn't should probably be investigated further and its legitimacy checked.

Being affiliated with a well-known association has many advantages and can open up opportunities to train with world-class instructors at visiting seminars. It also gives you the opportunity to be part of a larger team, which is great fun at competitions and events.

Being affiliated with some form of a governing body, for example, the UKBJJA in the UK, will ensure that the instructors conform to a strict set of rules and have things like DBS checks and first aid training in place.

How easily can you make it to the classes?

To improve at Jiu Jitsu, it is absolutely essential that you make it to class regularly and train consistently. Two main factors will influence this: your proximity to the academy and how well the class timetable fits your lifestyle.

The distance from your home or work to the academy makes a big difference in whether or not you will make it to the classes regularly. The closer you are, the more likely you are to attend. It is worth keeping in mind, however, that there are situations where you might want to train at an academy located further away because you enjoy the classes more, or the type of training suits your needs better.

The class timetable is also very important. For example, if you are a shift worker and can't make evening classes regularly, look for an academy that has some daytime classes that you can attend.

What are the classes like?

Classes can vary tremendously between different academies. The style of instruction, curriculum, amount of sparring and general vibe can be massively different from place to place. Most academies offer a free trial class or free training period, and you should attend at least one class before you commit to signing up. When attending

trial classes, try to get a feel for the different teaching styles at different academies and see which one you enjoy more, and which one suits your learning style best.

How busy are the classes? Classes with very few students present will limit your learning opportunities, as you will only have a very limited number of different training partners available. Quiet classes often have less of a buzz than busy classes, too, and this can sometimes make the classes less enjoyable. Conversely, classes that are far too busy are also less than ideal because you are much less likely to get attention from the instructor. Overly busy classes can also sometimes increase the risk of injury because of the limited space available between people training. Typically, a good number of students on the mat at one time is between 15 and 35. Daytime classes will usually be quieter, though, even at larger academies.

What are facilities like at the academy?

When you visit a prospective academy, make sure you check out the facilities. The foremost of this should be hygiene. Check that the mats are cleaned regularly, minimising the risk of infections, such as ringworm and staph. You should not have to compromise your health by training.

Showers and changing areas are valuable assets, particularly if you train before or after work or travel a long distance to the academy. Training Jiu Jitsu is very physical, and you will sweat a lot, so ideally, you will want to be able to shower and change before getting on public transport or embarking on a long car journey.

Another important and often overlooked factor is the availability of parking. If you are going to be driving to class, you need to ensure that you will be able to park your car nearby.

What are the students like?

You can gain a lot of information about an academy from the students who train there. A healthy, well-established academy will have a broad range of different students of different ages, genders, and belt rankings. Most large academies have lots of white belts, a good number of blue belts, quite a few purple belts and a handful of brown and black belts. This diversity of belt ranges will give you fantastic, different training opportunities and maximise your learning potential. If there are large numbers of white belts but hardly any coloured belts, this is a bit of a red flag as it indicates the academy is having trouble retaining students or getting them to a more advanced level.

Were the students friendly and welcoming? You obviously want to train in a pleasant environment where you can get on with the other students, make friends and have fun. The school's vibe is such an important factor when choosing an academy. Listen to your instincts on this, and make sure you feel that you can see yourself having fun and learning at your chosen place of training.

Do they have a beginner's program?

A beginner's program is a massive asset to an academy. Instilling sound Jiu Jitsu fundamentals in the early stages of your training is akin to building the foundations of a house. The stronger these foundations are, the stronger your game will be as you move through the ranks. While not having a beginner's program is not necessarily a deal breaker when looking for an academy, it certainly should be considered a very appealing attribute.

Are the classes good value for money?

Jiu Jitsu is generally quite an expensive martial art to train in. There are numerous reasons for this. The academies are often much larger than many traditional martial

arts, with higher overheads and more instructors required. There are also far fewer 'hobbyist' instructors teaching, and most Jiu Jitsu instructors are doing so professionally and have been training vast numbers of hours for over ten years to get to the stage where they can teach. With that being said, it is essential that you can afford to train. Different academies have very different pricing structures depending on the nature of how they run and what is available.

You should also factor in that you will need to purchase kit and equipment to train, which can also be expensive. You will likely need a gi/kimono, rashguard and gumshield at a bare minimum. If you want to train no-gi, you will likely also need shorts and perhaps spats. Some academies make it mandatory that you buy their own club or association-branded gear, which is also worth enquiring about before you sign up.

Many larger academies also have other benefits to joining that will provide additional value. Check to see if they have other martial arts classes also, such as Muay Thai, wrestling, Judo or MMA. Some classes also have yoga or conditioning classes that you can attend.

Summary

In summary, try to be as organised as possible, considering the questions posed above, when choosing an academy. Make sure you take at least one trial class and take your time when making the final decision.

When you find the right one, you will know. It will feel welcoming, challenging, and like somewhere you can actually see yourself growing.

Once you have, the next step is simple. Get on the mat and start training.

Chapter 4: Your First Jiu Jitsu Class

That first class can feel like a big deal. You're excited, a bit nervous, maybe not sure what to expect. That's normal. Everyone feels that way the first time they walk onto the mat.

Some of you will be completely new to martial arts. Others might have done a bit of karate, boxing, Judo, or something else before. Either way, Jiu Jitsu feels different. Every academy runs things slightly their own way, but most follow a similar structure. My hope here is to give you a feel for what happens and a few tips that'll make your first experience smoother.

Preparing for your first class

Before you just turn up, drop the academy a quick message. It is polite, and it saves you from showing up to the wrong session. Some schools require beginners to book or attend a specific class.

You will need a few basics. Loose gym clothes are fine, for example, shorts or joggers and a T-shirt. Avoid anything with zippers, cords, or buttons, and remove any jewellery. Those things can scratch or cut someone by accident.

Bring flip-flops to wear from the changing room to the mat. Use them if you go to the toilet or anywhere off the mats. It sounds small, but it keeps everyone safe from skin infections like ringworm or staph. Pack some water too. You will sweat more than you expect.

Hygiene is crucial in Jiu Jitsu. Come to class clean. Maybe even have a quick shower before you go, and trim your fingernails and toenails. Long nails are an easy way to cut someone accidentally, and infections spread fast.

Arriving at the venue

Allow yourself plenty of time to get there. Aim to arrive fifteen or twenty minutes early. That gives you time to get changed, find your bearings, and meet the instructor. You will probably need to fill out a quick form or waiver, too.

Most gyms are friendly. Someone will show you around and help you find what you need. If you're standing around before class starts, say hello to a few people. You will probably find that most of them remember exactly how it felt to be new and will make you feel at ease.

The warm-up

Classes usually start with a warm-up. Some are short and easy-going, focusing on mobility or stretching. Others are more physical and get the heart rate up. It depends on the instructor and what's planned for the rest of the session.

If the class is mostly technique-based, the warm-up will probably be lighter. If there's sparring coming up, expect something a bit tougher to get your body ready.

Technique and drilling

After warming up, the instructor will demonstrate a technique or short sequence. You will then pair up and practise it. Watch closely and try to take in the key details. At first, it'll feel like your brain can't keep up. That's normal. Everyone feels like that in the beginning.

When you start drilling, go slow. Focus on the movement, not the power. Don't rush or muscle through the technique. Once it feels smoother, you can increase the pace. Let your partner do the same.

And don't be afraid to ask questions. Instructors expect it. If you're struggling, speak up. It is how you learn.

Rolling and sparring

This is the part that scares most beginners – live sparring, or “rolling”. It is also the part most people end up loving.

There are usually two kinds. The first is specific sparring, where you start from a set position, like mount or side control. Each person has a clear goal. The person on top might be trying to submit, and the person underneath might be trying to escape.

The second is randori, or live rolling. It is less structured. You might start from your knees or standing, depending on the academy. You move, attack, defend, and reset when someone taps or the round ends.

Tapping is the safety system. If you're caught in a choke or joint lock, just tap your partner or the mat, or say “tap” clearly. Do it early and without hesitation. It is not a sign of weakness; it is part of training. Everyone taps, even black belts.

The first few rounds will probably feel chaotic. You will get tired fast. Try to breathe. That sounds obvious, but most beginners forget. Stay calm, keep breathing, and focus on surviving rather than winning. That's progress in itself.

The cool-down

After sparring, classes usually end with a short cool-down. You will stretch, loosen up, and let your heart rate come down. It is a small thing, but it really helps with recovery and reduces how sore you will feel later.

After the class

Once it is over, take a minute to speak to the instructor or someone from the team. Ask any questions you have – about memberships, timetables, or equipment. They'll be happy to help.

If you can, shower before you leave. You will feel better, and it is good manners. If you have got a long trip home, bring a quick snack and drink plenty of water. You will need it.

You might be sore for a day or two afterwards. That's completely normal. You have used muscles you didn't know existed. Stretch a bit that evening, or use a foam roller if you have one. And try to get a decent night's sleep. Your body will thank you.

What happens next?

Your first class is usually the hardest one you will ever do. You're out of your comfort zone and trying to take in a lot all at once. But you did it. You made it through.

If you enjoyed it, the next step is simple. Sign up, keep training, and don't overthink it. Two or three classes a week is perfect when you're starting.

Stick with it. The soreness fades. The confusion fades. Before long, it'll be part of your routine – something you look forward to.

Welcome to Jiu Jitsu. You have already done the hardest part.

Chapter 5: Essential Gear and Equipment

Like most sports, Jiu Jitsu needs a bit of gear. You don't have to buy everything at once, but a few things are essential if you want to train properly. What you choose after that depends on your goals, comfort, and budget.

To make things simple, I will break it down into three categories:

- The essentials
- No-gi training gear
- Protective equipment

The essentials

There are only two things you absolutely need to train at almost every Jiu Jitsu academy:

- A gi
- A belt

The gi is your uniform. Brazilian Jiu Jitsu was developed from Judo, and the gi has been part of that tradition ever since. The word “gi” comes from the Japanese term *keikogi* — *keiko* means “to practise”, and *gi* means “clothing”. In Brazil, you will often hear it called a *kimono*.

Jiu Jitsu gis are strong, thick, and built to take a lot of pulling and gripping. They look similar to Judo gis but fit tighter around the arms and body. You will find all sorts of colours, weaves, and cuts. Choosing one can feel confusing at first, but don't overthink it – most people just start with a good mid-weight gi and adjust later.



To train Jiu Jitsu, you will definitely need a 'gi'

Weight:

The weight of a gi is usually measured in grams per square metre (GSM). A 450 GSM gi is a good all-round choice. Heavier gis last longer and are harder for your opponent to grip, but they can feel hot and heavy. If you train in warm weather, look for a lighter 350 GSM gi.

Weave:

The weave is how the threads are woven together. A single weave is the lightest and

thinnest. A double weave is thick and heavy. The most popular is the pearl weave, which strikes a good balance between comfort and durability.

Cut:

Each brand has its own fit. Some are looser through the shoulders or tighter around the waist. With time, you will figure out which style suits your body and your game best.

Size:

Sizes usually start from A0 and go up from there. A2 fits most average-sized adults, but check the size chart carefully. Some brands offer long (L) or husky (H) versions for different body shapes, such as A2L for tall, slim people or A2H for shorter, stockier builds.

The other essential is your belt. The belt shows your rank and progress. You will start with white and, over time, move through blue, purple, and brown before reaching black.

Because belts last a long time, it is worth buying a good one. Go for a heavier, well-made belt that won't wear out quickly. It should have a black bar at one end – this is where your instructor will place stripes as you progress.

The belt should be long enough to wrap around your waist twice with a little extra left over. The size often matches your gi (A2, A3, etc.), but always double-check before buying.



It is worthwhile to invest in a high-quality heavyweight belt that won't wear out quickly.

No-Gi Training Gear

If you plan to train no-gi as well, you will need a few extra pieces:

- Rashguard
- Grappling shorts
- Spats

Rashguards are tight-fitting compression tops. They help wick away sweat, prevent mat burns, and reduce the spread of skin infections like ringworm. Some academies even require them under the gi for hygiene reasons.

When training no-gi, a rashguard is essential. Avoid cotton T-shirts as they get heavy, stretch out, and tear easily.



You should really invest in a rashguard.

Grappling shorts are another must-have. Regular gym or board shorts aren't suitable because they often have zips, pockets, or loops that can catch fingers or toes. Proper fight shorts are designed to stretch where you need them, stay in place, and survive years of training. They are safer, more comfortable, and made from durable materials that won't rip easily.

Spats are compression leggings worn under your shorts. They prevent chafing, protect your skin from mat burns, and help keep things hygienic. Some people prefer them, others don't – it is really down to comfort and habit.

Protective equipment

Protective gear is optional. Some people use a lot, others hardly any. It often depends on your build, injuries, and how hard you train. Common items include:

- Mouthguard
- Ear guards
- Groin protector
- Knee pads

Mouthguards (or gum shields) are the most common. They protect your teeth, gums, and jaw, and can help absorb impact from accidental knocks. There are three main types:

- Stock mouthguards (cheap and ready-made, but poor fit)
- Boil-and-bite mouthguards (softened in hot water and moulded to your teeth)
- Custom-made mouthguards (done by a dentist for the best fit and protection)

Ear guards help prevent cauliflower ear – a swelling of the cartilage caused by repeated friction or impact. They are not for everyone, but if your ears are getting sore, it might be worth wearing them. Look for soft neoprene types that fit comfortably and won't dig in.

Groin protectors are used less often. They are self-explanatory but not allowed in competition and can make certain submissions go on faster. Most people skip them unless they are recovering from an injury.

Knee pads can help if you have sore knees or past injuries. They offer extra cushioning and warmth. Some people wear them every session, others never bother.

Final thoughts

You don't need to buy everything on day one. Start with the basics – a gi, a belt, a rashguard and a good attitude. The rest can come later as you figure out what suits you.

Good equipment won't make you better overnight, but it makes training safer and more comfortable. And comfort means you will keep coming back, which is what really matters.

Chapter 6: Jiu Jitsu Mat Etiquette

Every Jiu Jitsu academy has its own rules. Some are written on the wall, some are on the website, and some you just pick up over time. The details vary from place to place, but the basics are always the same – show respect, look after your training partners, and keep the place clean.

Good etiquette isn't about being strict or formal. It is about keeping everyone safe and making sure the mats stay a good place to train. Nobody wants to be that person who upsets half the class without realising it.

Health and hygiene

Let's start with hygiene, because it is a big one. Jiu Jitsu is close contact. You will be sweating, grabbing, and rolling around with people, so it is essential to stay clean. If you're unwell, don't train. Even a mild cold or cough can spread quickly through a gym. The same goes for any skin infection – ringworm, herpes, staph, whatever. Stay home, get treated, and come back when it is completely gone.

Turn up clean, with a washed gi. That should go without saying, but it is amazing how often it needs saying. If you know you tend to smell strong after training, use deodorant before class as a courtesy to everyone else.

Trim your fingernails and toenails. Long nails cut people, and those cuts can get infected fast. Keep a small pair of nail clippers in your gym bag – they'll come in handy more than once.

Take off all jewellery and piercings before you step on the mat, even wedding rings. They can scratch, tear, or get caught. If you can't remove a ring or piercing, tape it up securely instead.

Never walk on the mats in shoes, and never walk off the mats barefoot. Keep a pair of flip-flops or sliders for getting to and from the training area or the bathroom. It sounds small, but that's how infections spread – and it really annoys instructors when people forget.

If you cut yourself or start bleeding, stop immediately. Clean it, cover it, and let your instructor know so they can disinfect the area. It is just basic respect for the people you're training with.

General conduct at the academy

Try to arrive on time. It is not just about respect, it is also practical. You will miss the warm-up if you're late, and that's how people pull muscles or tweak joints. If you are running late, wait off the mats until the instructor invites you on.

Turn your phone off or on silent before class. A ringing phone kills the focus in the room. If you want to film something for later, always ask the instructor first. Some are fine with it, others prefer you don't.

Keep your focus on Jiu Jitsu. The mat isn't the place for gossip, complaining, or arguments about politics or religion. It is also not the place to moan about other students or instructors. If you have a genuine issue, talk to the person involved or to your instructor privately.

Most people come to Jiu Jitsu to escape stress, not add to it. Be the kind of person who makes the room better, not the one who drains the energy.

Conduct during class

When the instructor is teaching, pay attention. Don't talk over them or sit scrolling through your phone. Keep your posture respectful – sitting up, watching, listening.

Questions are fine, but keep them short and on topic. There's usually time for questions after the instructor finishes showing a move, so try to wait until then.

When it is time to drill, stick to the technique being taught. This isn't the moment to test out a move you saw online last night. The instructor has chosen what to teach for a reason. Also, don't start coaching your partner — that's the instructor's job. Just train, listen, and help each other get the technique right.

Conduct during sparring

Sparring (or rolling) is where things can go wrong fast if you're not careful. Always remember, this is training, not fighting. Your goal is to learn, not to "win". Keep your pace under control. If you go too hard, your partner will match your energy, and soon both of you are going flat out. It is not worth it. Try to stay calm, breathe, and focus on applying technique.

Respect the tap. Tap early, and release straight away when your partner taps. Never hold onto a submission, never crank something on fast, and never try to prove a point. If you think your partner doesn't understand the danger they are in, just let it go. Their safety matters more than your ego.

Be aware of differences in size, strength, and experience. A small purple belt might move better than a big white belt, but strength still matters. If you're the heavier or stronger one, control yourself. The goal is for both people to leave in one piece.

Watch out for others around you. If you bump into another pair, stop and move. Lower belts usually move for higher belts, but either way, do it quickly. And when the instructor calls time, stop immediately — even if you're seconds away from a submission.

Stay humble. Don't celebrate after a tap or brag about who you caught. Everyone gets tapped. The longer you train, the more you will realise how little it means.

That's really all there is to it. Be clean. Be respectful. Keep people safe.

If you can do that, you will fit in anywhere you train.

Chapter 7: The Fundamental Positions

One of the most important aspects of Jiu Jitsu is understanding and using the fundamental positions effectively. These positions form the base for everything else. They allow you to control, manipulate and submit your opponent.

In this chapter, we will examine the primary positions, the underlying principles behind them, and the key strategies and pitfalls to be aware of. By the end, you should have a clear understanding of each position and how to apply it in training..

The seven most important positions for beginners to understand are:

1. Standing
2. Guard
3. Side control
4. Knee-on-belly
5. Full mount
6. Back control
7. Turtle

1. Standing

The standing position is one of the most important areas of Jiu Jitsu, yet it is often overlooked early on. Every match or self-defence situation starts standing, so it is vital to understand the basics. While it may appear simple, stand-up grappling is a complex and demanding skill that requires balance, timing, and precision.



The standing position is one of the most important aspects of Jiu Jitsu.

The first thing to get right is posture. Good posture gives you balance, keeps you stable, and helps you defend against takedowns. Stand with your weight evenly distributed on both feet, neither too upright nor too bent over, and keep your hands protecting your lapels to prevent easy access. Avoid leaning too far forward or back.

Your centre of gravity sits a few centimetres below your navel. The lower it is, the more stable you become. Think of this when setting your stance – a lower base generally means better balance.

Grip fighting is another essential skill. Whoever controls the grips usually controls the exchange. Grips let you move your opponent, break their balance, and set up throws or takedowns. You will see a variety of grips used, including collar and sleeve grips, lapel grips, and over-under clinches. Stay active with your hands and be ready to adjust.

The goal from standing is to bring the fight to the ground on your terms. This can be done through Judo-style throws, trips, or wrestling-style takedowns. Throws rely on leverage and timing, trips use leg sweeps, and wrestling takedowns focus on controlling the hips and legs. You may also choose to pull guard, especially if your opponent has stronger stand-up skills than you or if you're confident in your guard game.

2. Guard

The guard is the position you will encounter most often in Jiu Jitsu. It is also one of the hardest to master. The guard describes any position where you are on your back, using your legs to control your opponent's body.

There are three main types of guard:

- Closed guard
- Open guard
- Half guard

a. Closed guard

In closed guard, the person on the bottom, known as the guard player, wraps their legs around the waist of the person on top, known as the passer, and locks their ankles together. It is the position most beginners use and one of the safest and most versatile in Jiu Jitsu. From here, the guard player can control their opponent, attack with submissions, or sweep to gain the top position.



In closed guard, the guard player has their legs wrapped around the waist of the passer with their ankles closed together.

One of the main advantages of the closed guard is posture control. By keeping the legs tightly wrapped around the opponent's waist, the guard player can stop them from standing up or posturing too high, which makes it difficult to strike or pass effectively.

Closed guard also offers a range of submission options. The most common include the triangle choke, arm bar, and guillotine. The triangle choke uses the legs to cut off blood flow to the neck, while the arm bar isolates the opponent's arm and applies pressure to the elbow joint. Both are highly effective when done with good control.

Beyond submissions, closed guard allows for sweeps that reverse the position and put you on top. Sweeps rely on breaking the passer's balance and using your legs and hips to roll or toss them over. There are many different ways to sweep from closed guard, and once you develop a feel for the timing, they can be an excellent way to turn defence into attack. The guard player can also transition to back control, often referred to as a "back take", if the opportunity arises.

For the top player, the main goal is to "pass the guard," meaning to move past the opponent's legs and secure a dominant position. Guard passing can be achieved through pressure, movement, or submission-based approaches. Pressure passing relies on using your weight and leverage to pin the opponent's legs and create openings. Movement passing utilises quick, explosive movements to get around the legs, while submission passing involves threatening with attacks, such as the Kimura, to force reactions and open up space for the pass.

b. Open guard

In open guard, the guard player's legs are not locked around the passer's torso. It is probably the most complex of all the fundamental positions and one of the most popular because it offers such a wide range of attacks, sweeps, and transitions.

There are countless variations – de la Riva guard, butterfly guard, lasso guard, X-guard, tornado guard, worm guard, spider guard and many others. Each has its own techniques and strategies. On top of these established variations, open guard also allows a lot of creativity and improvisation. It is a faster-paced, more dynamic position than closed guard, and there tend to be far more sweeping opportunities as a result.



The open guard is probably the most complex of all the positions in Jiu Jitsu.

It is important to acknowledge that the open guard has its weaknesses. It can be hard to maintain against a skilled passer, as the guard is already “open,” making it easier to bypass. It also leaves the legs more exposed to attacks such as straight foot locks. Open guard requires good hip mobility, balance, and flexibility, which can make it difficult for some practitioners to use effectively.

Even with these challenges, open guard is an essential part of modern Jiu Jitsu. It rewards movement, timing, and creativity, and learning to use it well will open up a huge part of your game.

c. Half guard

In half guard, the guard player controls one of the top player's legs between their own. It is called "half" guard because it offers only partial control compared to the full, closed guard.



In the half guard, one of the top grappler's legs is controlled by the guard player's legs.

Half guard has become hugely popular over the past decade or so, with many high-level competitors building their entire game around it. It sits somewhere between

offence and defence – not as secure as closed guard, but full of opportunities if used well.

As with other guard variations, there are many sweeps, submissions, and back takes available. Most attacks begin by controlling the passer's knee and hips with your legs. The key for the bottom player is to stay on their side rather than flat on their back. From this angle, you can use your forearms to frame and prevent the top player from driving forward with pressure.

For the passer, the goal is the opposite – flatten your opponent and control their head. Once you establish strong head and shoulder control, it becomes much easier to pass or attack. Unlike the other guard positions, half guard offers more submission options for the top player, too, including collar chokes and figure-four armlocks, which can often be set up directly from inside the position.

3. Side Control

In side control, the top player lies perpendicular across their opponent, applying pressure through the chest. It is one of the most dominant positions in Jiu Jitsu. Most players reach side control after passing the guard, but it can also come directly from a takedown or a sweep. From here, the top player can apply pressure, attack submissions, and transition into other dominant positions.



In side control, the top grappler is perpendicular to their opponent, with their weight applied to the opponent's chest.

From the top, the goal is to keep heavy pressure and limit your opponent's movement. Use your body weight and leverage to drive into their chest and control their upper body. You can use your arms to trap the head or block the near-side hip to stop escapes. Side control has numerous small variations, each offering slightly different angles and levels of pressure. It is a versatile position that allows you to adapt as your opponent moves.

A wide range of submissions can be attacked from here, and it is also an ideal platform for improving position – moving to mount, knee-on-belly, or even taking the back.

For the bottom player, the priority is to escape. This can be one of the toughest tasks for beginners, which is why it is worth focusing on side control escapes early in your training. The key is to stop your opponent from controlling your head. Once your head is pinned, movement becomes very limited. Keep your elbows and forearms tight between your torso and theirs to create a frame. From there, you can begin to push, make space, and work your way back to guard or another safer position.

4. Knee-on-belly

Knee-on-belly is a dominant and highly effective position that allows the top player to control their opponent while setting up submissions or transitions. It is most often entered from side control, and when done correctly, it provides excellent pressure and mobility simultaneously.

Technically, “knee-on-chest” might be a more accurate name. For optimal control, the top player should have their knee angled diagonally across the opponent’s chest, with the toes hooked around the far hip and off the floor. This puts maximum weight through the opponent’s torso and keeps your arms close to their upper body and neck, creating plenty of opportunities to attack.

From knee-on-belly, you can transition smoothly into submissions like the cross choke, arm bar, or Kimura. You can also use it as a launch pad to move into mount or back control. Unlike other control positions, it offers a high level of mobility – you can move quickly, switch sides, and adjust pressure without giving up control. It is also an incredibly uncomfortable position for the person underneath, often forcing them to make mistakes.



In the knee-on-belly position, the top grappler has his knee on the torso of the bottom grappler.

However, knee-on-belly isn't without weaknesses. It is far less stable than side control and can be tricky to hold, especially for beginners who haven't yet developed strong balance and weight distribution. It takes time and experience to make this position truly effective.

For the bottom player, the main goal is to escape. The simplest method is to remove the knee from the torso and recover to side control. While not ideal, side control is far easier to defend from. Another option is to trap the leg and work back to half guard, or even use the momentum to roll the top player over. Whatever escape you

attempt, avoid pushing directly on the knee, as this leaves your arm exposed to attacks such as armlocks and Kimuras.

5. Full mount

In the full mount position, the top player sits astride their opponent's torso, with their knees and feet on the ground beside them. It is one of the most dominant positions in Jiu Jitsu, second only to back control in the hierarchy of positional dominance.

The key to full mount is control. The person on top must manage the opponent's hips and shoulders to stop them from escaping. Good posture, balance, and weight distribution are essential. The top player should use their bodyweight and gravity to apply steady pressure while staying ready to adjust to movement underneath.

From mount, there are many attacking options – chokes, armlocks, and transitions into even stronger positions. The back take is particularly common if the bottom player rolls onto their stomach to defend. With practice, full mount becomes both a powerful attacking platform and one of the most secure positions in the art.



Many attacking options are available from the full mount, especially chokes and armlocks.

6. Back control

Back control is the most dominant and sought-after position in Brazilian Jiu-Jitsu, and is often referred to as the “king of all positions.” From here, the attacker has complete control and a wide range of submission options.

To establish back control, the attacker positions themselves behind the opponent and controls both the upper and lower body. The upper body is controlled using a

seatbelt grip, with one arm over the shoulder and one arm under the armpit, locking the hands together in front of the chest. This grip keeps the attacker connected and prevents easy escapes.



Back control is such a dominant position because the defender's neck is exposed, making them vulnerable to chokes and strangles.

Control of the lower body comes from the hooks – the attacker's legs wrapped around the opponent's waist, with the feet engaged and active to move in sync with the opponent. Keeping the hooks tight helps maintain control and limits the defender's ability to move.

Back control is so powerful because the opponent's neck is exposed, making them vulnerable to chokes. The most well-known attack from this position is the rear naked choke, where one arm slides under the chin and the arms are squeezed together to apply pressure on both sides of the neck.

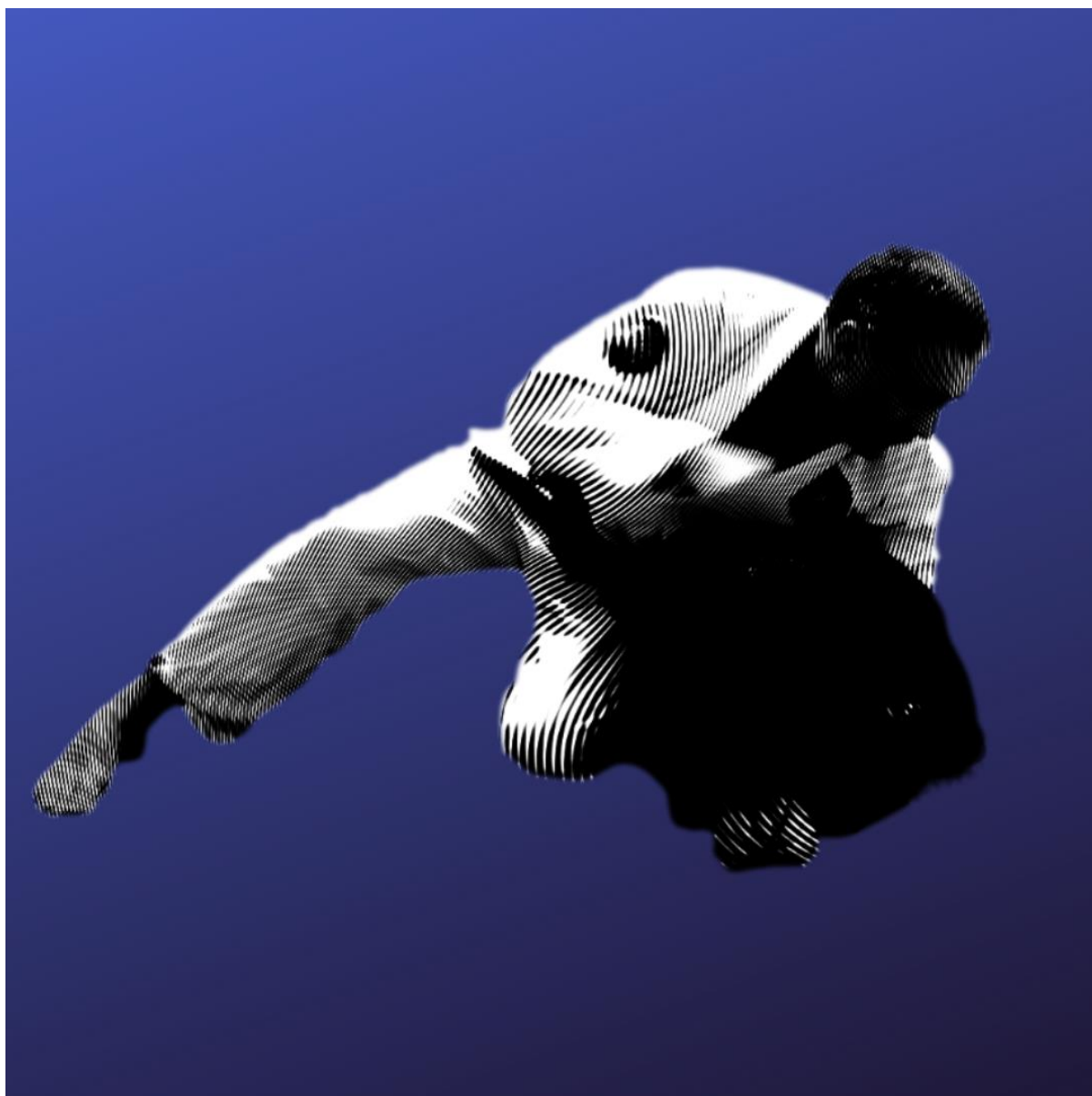
When defending, the main priority is to protect the neck at all costs. Once the choke threat is under control, the next goal is to escape to a safer position. One of the most common escapes is to bridge the head and shoulders toward the floor on the underhook side, then use the hips to shrimp out and either turn into the opponent's guard or recover to side control.

7. Turtle

The turtle position is an "in-between" position that often occurs when a defender escapes from a dominant position, such as mount or side control. It is one of the most mobile defensive positions in Jiu Jitsu, allowing for quick movement and transitions in almost any direction.

In the turtle position, the defender is on all fours with their back rounded and head tucked down toward their chest. The arms protect the head and neck, while the legs help create space or push off the mat to escape. By staying compact and keeping the elbows tucked tight over the thighs, the defender can protect against hooks and make it difficult for the attacker to take the back.

From the top, the attacker has several options – submissions, back takes, or turning the opponent over into side control. However, a tight turtle can be frustrating to attack. Breaking it down often requires patience, balance, and careful timing to find openings without giving up position.



The turtle position is an 'in-between' position in that it usually occurs after a defender has escaped from a more powerful position such as mount or side mount.

Chapter 8: Positional Hierarchy

The concept of positional hierarchy is central to understanding Jiu Jitsu. It refers to how different positions rank in terms of control and advantage. Not all positions are equal, and some offer far greater dominance and safety than others.

In a match, both players are constantly trying to achieve positional dominance. Being in a dominant position usually means gravity and leverage are on your side. You're also safer because your opponent will find it harder to apply submissions or use strength effectively against you.

Understanding this hierarchy helps you make better decisions and prioritise movements as you work through positions during a roll or match.

The concept of positional dominance

Moving through the main positions in Jiu Jitsu is a bit like climbing a ladder. Each step gives you more control and better opportunities to attack.

The guard sits in the middle of the ladder and is generally considered the most neutral position. Some players prefer to stay on their backs, using guard to attack or sweep and advance. Others prefer to pass the guard, moving into side control to take a more dominant role. Neither the top nor the bottom has a clear advantage here; it depends on skill, timing, and strategy.

Side control ranks above guard in the hierarchy. From here, the top player has stronger control and more attacking options. Knee-on-belly can be seen as a variation of side control. In some ways, it is even more dominant because of the attacking angles it opens up, but it also gives up a bit of stability, so the two positions sit roughly on the same level.

Next comes the mount. From mount, the top player has excellent control over the opponent's upper body and access to a wide range of chokes and armlocks. It also creates the opportunity to advance further – if the bottom player rolls to defend, the top player can take the back.

At the top of the hierarchy sits back control, often referred to as the “king of all positions.” It gives the attacker the highest level of control and direct access to the opponent's neck for chokes and strangles.

There are, of course, many other positions in Jiu Jitsu – open guard, half guard, north-south, turtle – each with its own balance of control and vulnerability. Understanding how they all fit together will help you think more clearly about strategy and movement on the mat.

The positional ladder

Most experienced instructors and high-level practitioners agree that the positional ladder can be summarised as follows:

Guard → Side control → Mount → Back control

Each step represents an improvement in control and attack potential.



The concept of transitioning

To move from one position to a more dominant one, you have to go through what's called a transition. A transition is the brief moment in a match when neither player has complete control, or when you are moving from one position to another.

Your aim during any transition should be simple – finish in a stronger position than the one you started from. If you decide to move, make sure it ends with you gaining an advantage.

Well-timed transitions can become a form of control in themselves. The very best grapplers move so smoothly and quickly between dominant positions that their opponents never get a chance to settle, defend or regain balance.

The basic formula

Jiu Jitsu can be simplified into a basic formula:

1. Take your opponent to the ground using a throw or takedown.
2. Transition to a dominant position as efficiently as possible.
3. Use leverage to finish with a choke, strangle, or joint lock.

Or, even more simply:

Takedown → Transition → Position → Submission

Your goal should always be to improve your position or finish the fight with a submission. Many beginners skip the “position” stage and rush straight for the submission. The problem is that without solid positional control, finishing an opponent becomes much harder.

If you want to develop quickly, don’t fixate on submissions too early. Focus on building positional control first. Learn to hold and move through dominant positions with confidence, and once you can do that, submissions will come naturally.

Chapter 9: The Five Essential Movements

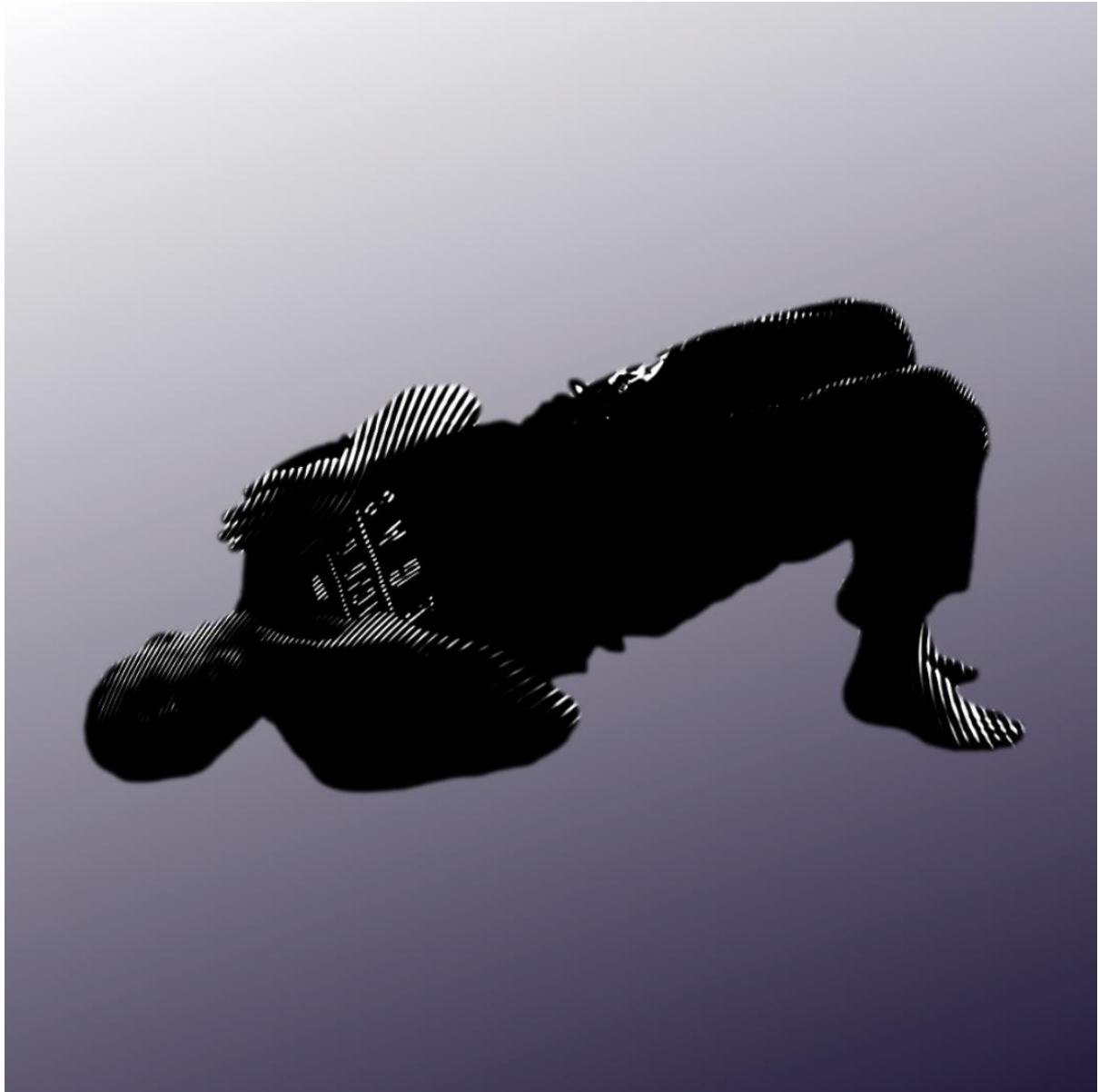
If you are new to Jiu Jitsu, there are five basic movements you should focus on first. These form the foundation of nearly everything you will learn on the mats. Mastering them will make every technique easier to understand and perform, and they will help you move more confidently in every position.

1. Bridging

Bridging is one of the first movements you will use in Jiu Jitsu. It involves lifting your hips off the ground and using your feet, shoulders, and head to generate power. It is essential for escaping bad positions, creating space, and even setting up sweeps or submissions.

To perform a bridge, lie on your back with your knees bent and your feet flat on the floor. Push through your feet to lift your hips, arching your back so your shoulders come slightly off the mat. The power should come from your legs and hips – not your arms or upper body.

Bridging is the foundation of many escapes, and learning to do it smoothly will improve your defence right away.



Bridging is a crucial movement in many escapes.

2. Shrimping

Shrimping, or hip escape, is another key movement that goes hand in hand with bridging. It teaches you how to move your hips to create space — one of the most important skills in escaping bad positions like mount or side control.

To shrimp, start on your side with your knees bent and your feet on the mat. Push through your feet and hips to drive your body backwards while keeping your chest

close to the ground. The goal is to move your hips away from your opponent, creating distance so you can re-guard or stand up.

Shrimping and bridging together form the backbone of Jiu Jitsu movement. You will use them constantly throughout your training.



Shrimping is another important movement in Jiu Jitsu and is often used in conjunction with bridging.

3. Back break falls

Learning how to fall safely is one of the most important skills in Jiu Jitsu. Break falls protect you when you are thrown or taken down and allow you to train with confidence. The most basic and useful to start with is the back break fall.

To perform it, squat with your feet shoulder-width apart. Cross your arms over your chest and relax your body as you fall backwards. Tuck your chin to your chest to stop your head from hitting the mat, then move your arms out to the sides at about a 45-degree angle with your palms facing down.

Good break-falling technique prevents injury and gives you the confidence to train hard and take falls safely.



Learning how to break fall effectively is a vital part of training in Jiu Jitsu.

4. Forward shoulder rolls

Forward shoulder rolls are another essential safety movement in Jiu Jitsu. They allow you to roll safely when you're thrown, taken down, or caught in a scramble, and they are also useful for escaping bad positions or regaining balance during transitions.

To perform a forward shoulder roll, start from a kneeling or crouched position. Thread one arm underneath the opposite armpit, tuck your chin tightly to your chest,

and guide your head toward the mat. Roll diagonally across your shoulder at about a 45-degree angle rather than straight over your head — this protects your neck and keeps the motion smooth.

Once you have practised it a few times, you will notice shoulder rolls appear naturally in your movement, especially during escapes and transitions.



Forward shoulder rolls allow you to roll safely when you are thrown by your opponent.

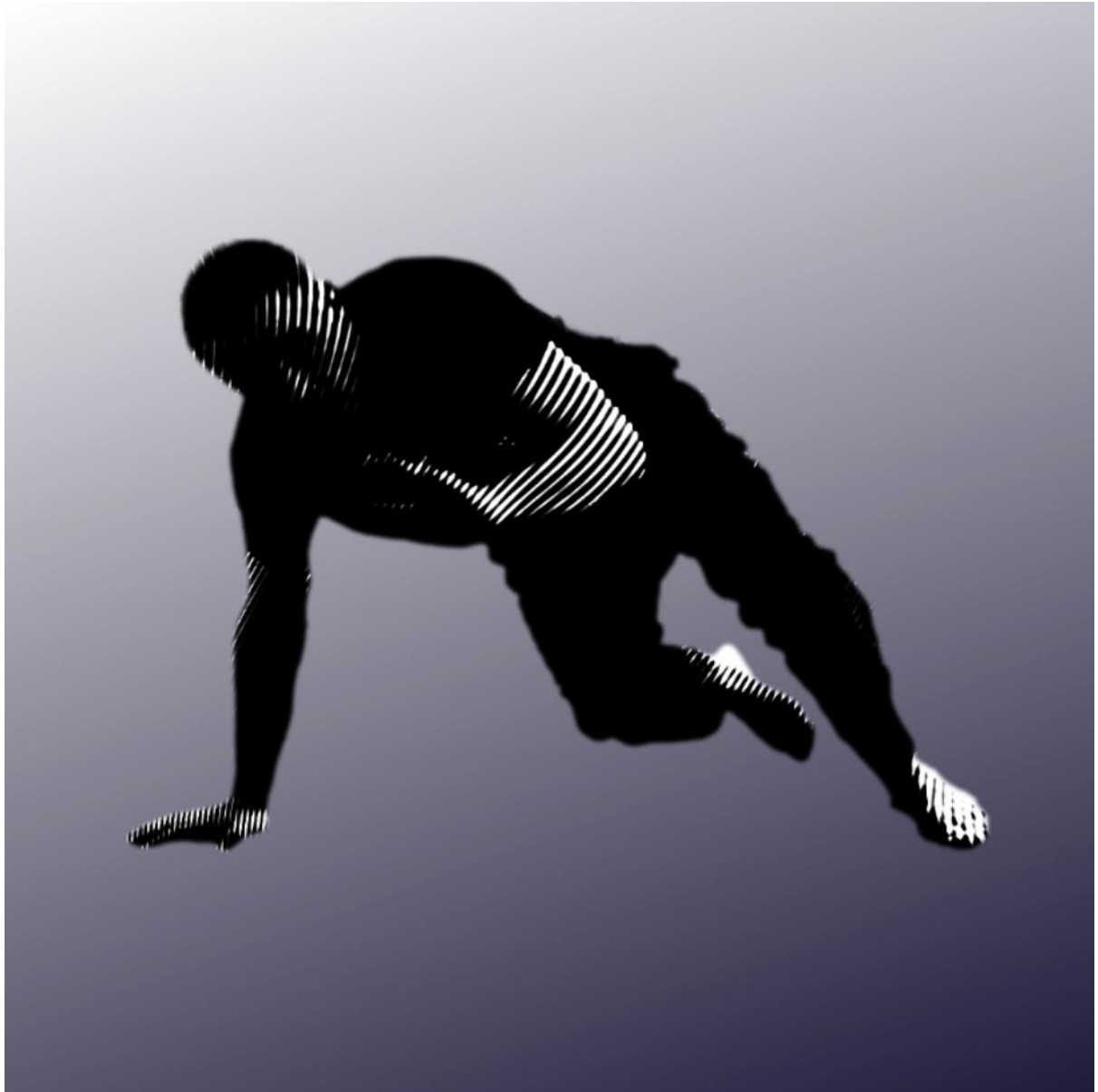
5. Technical stand-up

The technical stand-up is one of the most important movements in Jiu Jitsu. It teaches you how to return to your feet safely and efficiently after being taken down – a skill that's crucial for both sport and self-defence.

From a self-defence point of view, the ability to stand up correctly keeps you protected. When you're on the ground, you're at risk of being struck, so learning to create space and get back to your feet without exposing yourself is essential.

Beyond self-defence, the technical stand-up is a movement pattern that appears all over Jiu Jitsu. You will see its mechanics in sweeps, escapes, and transitions – for example, in the classic X-guard stand-up sweep.

Practising it also builds balance, coordination, and body control – qualities that carry over into every aspect of your training. Mastering this movement not only improves your ability to stand safely but also strengthens your overall foundation as a grappler.



Learning the technical stand-up in Jiu Jitsu is essential because it allows a practitioner to efficiently and effectively

Chapter 10: Reflections on My Early Days

When I look back on my early years of Jiu Jitsu, the most striking thing is how incredibly lucky I was. I started training at a time when Jiu Jitsu in the UK was still relatively young and almost underground. There were only two academies in London, and just four homegrown British black belts in the entire country. It felt like we were part of something secret that most people hadn't even heard of.

Because it was so new, everything carried a sense of discovery. Every class felt like stepping into unknown territory. There were no online tutorials, no BJJ Fanatics instructionals, and no shortcuts. You had to turn up, pay attention, and remember. You learned by showing up, getting smashed, asking questions, and trying again. It was raw and simple, and I think that's what made it so special.

The atmosphere in those early days was really unique. We were a small group of people completely hooked on something we barely understood. The mats were filled with laughter, exhaustion, and curiosity. We just wanted to learn. Looking back, I think that purity is what made those years so memorable.

Finding the academy I did felt like a stroke of luck and being surrounded by teachers who still shape me today seems even luckier. Steve Finan, a 4th-degree black belt under Mauricio Gomes now, was one of the first to take me under his wing. He shared his knowledge freely with technical expertise and endless patience. His teaching style had an understated precision that lingered long after the sessions ended. He didn't need to make a show of his ability, and I learned from him by feeling and by listening carefully.

Then there was Nic Gregoriades, Roger Gracie's first black belt. Nic opened my eyes to how creative Jiu Jitsu could be. He encouraged me to think for myself, to see the art as a form of expression rather than just combat. He made me realise that there was philosophy behind it, and that training could be both disciplined and deeply personal.

And of course, there is Mauricio. My teacher, my mentor, and someone I feel deeply honoured to have learned from. I was fortunate to form a close relationship with him, one that has shaped nearly everything I do in Jiu Jitsu and in life. Training under Mauricio was never just about technique. It was about pressure, awareness and composure. His lessons go far beyond the mat. Mauricio has the deepest understanding of Jiu Jitsu I have ever encountered. His mastery of the fundamentals is unmatched, and his pressure has to be felt to be believed. It is something you cannot quite explain in words. He is also one of the greatest storytellers I have ever met, able to hold a room in the palm of his hand with a single story, leaving everyone laughing, inspired, or both.



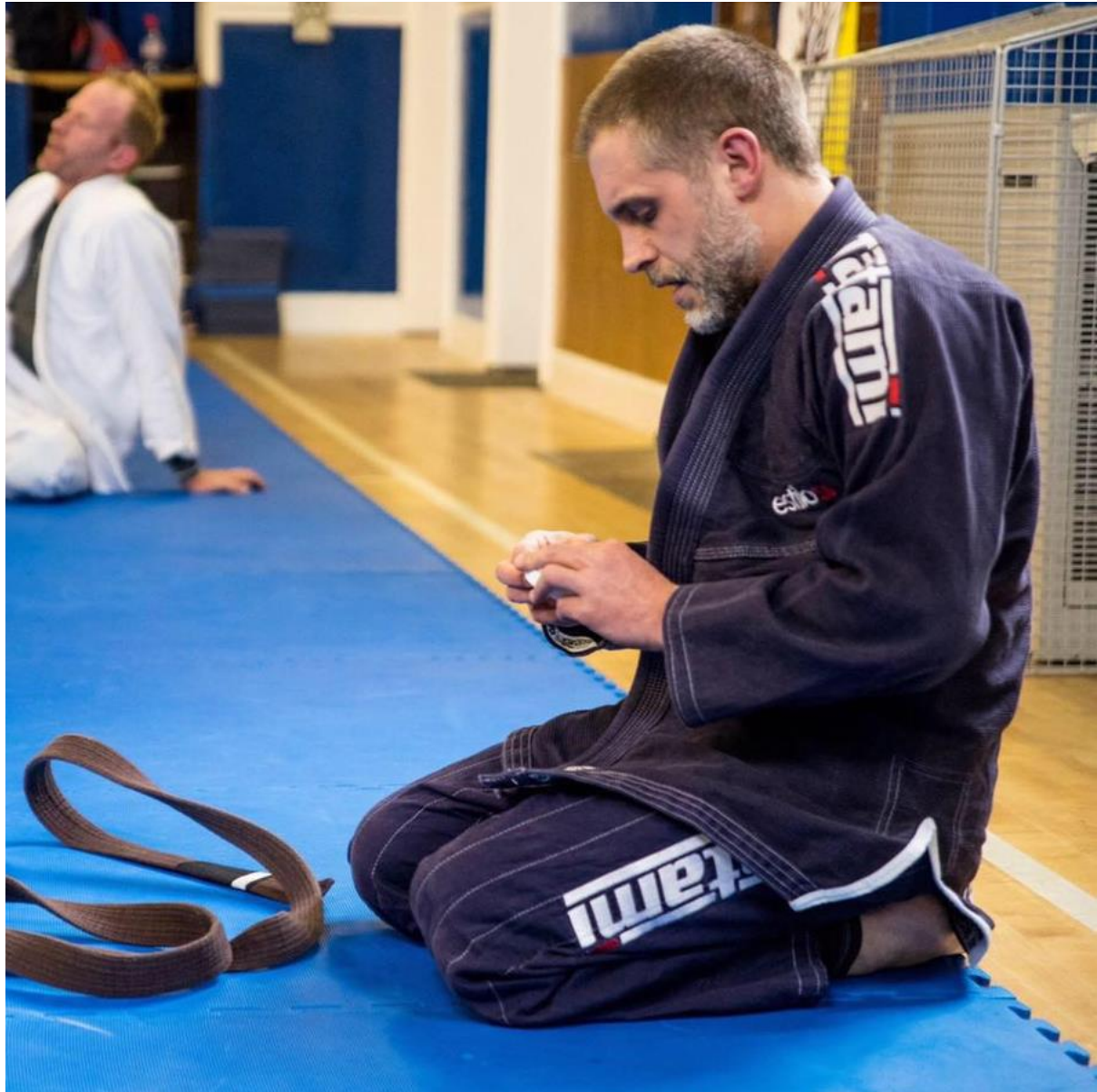
I've been so lucky with my teachers and training partners.

Much of how I now teach my classes comes directly from my experience as his uke. The pace, the structure, the emphasis on clarity – all of it grew from watching how he taught. When you stand next to him, you can feel the calm authority he carries. He

has a presence that fills the room, but it is never forced. Everyone listens, not because they have to, but because they want to.

If I could go back and change anything about those early years, I wouldn't change where I trained or who I trained with. I would change how I thought.

I spent far too much time worrying about bad days and comparing myself to others.



Don't take it all so seriously, Marc.

I'd leave the mat replaying mistakes in my head, wondering why I wasn't improving faster. What I eventually learned was that those tough sessions were the ones that

really mattered. They are the days that build you, even though you don't realise it at the time.

I remember one training partner in particular. We were about the same size, the same belt, and trained together constantly through blue and purple. He was hellishly tough and had a super technical guard. Guard passing was my strong suit, but I could never seem to pass his. No matter how hard I tried, every round ended the same way. I'd leave the gym dejected, convinced I wasn't a good enough training partner for him.

Months later, we were having coffee together and he told me something that completely changed my perspective. He admitted how much he hated rolling with me. He said he felt like I was always winning because he could never sweep me or land any of his usual submissions. We'd been locked in a stalemate for months; each convinced the other was getting the better of us. Both of us had built a whole story in our heads that wasn't remotely true. It taught me that how you feel about a situation often has very little to do with reality.

Something similar happened a couple of years later. One of my instructors came to teach a class at Kingston Jiu Jitsu. I was a brown belt at the time, and another brown belt from a different academy dropped in. He used to visit fairly often, and we always had tough, competitive rolls. I usually did well and felt I had the edge. That night, I was eager to show my instructor what I could do. I wanted to look sharp, to prove I'd been improving.

Instead, it was one of the worst rolls I'd had in months. Nothing clicked. My timing was off. I felt heavy, slow, frustrated, and got subbed twice. I left annoyed at myself for putting on such a poor showing. But later that evening, I realised what had really happened. I'd been so focused on impressing someone else that I forgot the point of training. It is not about performing for anyone. It is about learning, even when that means struggling. Especially when it means struggling.

If I could speak to my younger self, I'd tell him not to take it all so seriously. Progress in Jiu Jitsu isn't linear. It is full of peaks and plateaus. Some days you feel

unstoppable. Other days you can't do a thing right. That's part of the process. The key is to keep showing up, to trust that consistency will take care of the rest.

What I loved from the start was how much it felt like play. That sense of movement, of testing and exploring, reminded me of being a kid. For a few hours, everything else fell away. It didn't matter what kind of day you'd had or what was going on in your life. Once you stepped on the mat, all that disappeared. You just moved, reacted, and learned. It was a rare kind of freedom.

Jiu Jitsu helped me through some of the hardest periods of my life, especially during my years as a doctor. The work was intense, and there were days that felt overwhelming. But training gave me an outlet. It was a place to breathe, to reset, to remind myself that life existed outside the hospital walls. Over time, it gave me something even greater – the courage to make a change.

When I eventually left medicine to teach Jiu Jitsu full time, most people thought I was crazy. It was Oli Geddes who told me I wasn't.

Oli was one of my closest friends and one of the best people I've ever known. He was a teacher, a mentor, and a constant source of support. When I first made the decision to teach full time, he backed me completely. When I was unwell, he covered my classes without hesitation. He came round to my garden at night to teach me half guard under a torch. He dropped into Kingston Jiu Jitsu whenever he could, just to share knowledge and see how everyone was doing.

Oli was Britain's greatest homegrown black belt competitor, a brilliant referee, and one of the most dedicated instructors you could ever meet. His sense of humour was off the charts. He could make anyone laugh, even in the toughest moments. But more than that, he was humble, kind, and completely genuine. Losing him was devastating.



Oli teaching at Kingston Jiu Jitsu – always patient, funny, and endlessly generous with his knowledge.

When I teach now, I think about him often. About the way he made people feel seen and supported. About how much he gave to the sport and to everyone around him. There's a part of him in every class I teach.

As I write this, it has been nineteen years since I first stepped onto the mats, but I still feel the same excitement I did back then. I'm still learning, still improving, still grateful. Jiu Jitsu has given me more than I could ever repay – friendships, purpose, perspective, and a way to give something back.

When I see a nervous beginner walk into class for the first time, I always remember what that felt like. I know exactly where they are. And I know what's waiting for them if they stick with it – growth, community, and a sense of joy that will stay with them for the rest of their life.

I was incredibly fortunate to have started when I did, surrounded by the people I did. I'll always be grateful for that. And now, all I want is to help others experience that same sense of discovery. To give back to the art that gave me everything.

Chapter 11: Top Ten Tips for Beginners

I hope you have enjoyed this beginner's guide to Jiu Jitsu and that it has given you the confidence boost you need for the road ahead. The first few weeks can feel very uncertain. You will feel clumsy, unsure, and, at times, a bit lost. Everyone does. In fact, every black belt you will ever meet has been through precisely the same thing. The key is simply to keep turning up.

These ten tips are meant to help you get the most out of your early training.

1. Find a good school

Choosing the right academy is the first, and arguably the most crucial, step to take. Where you train will influence every aspect of your Jiu-Jitsu experience. A good school has clean mats, well-structured classes and a friendly, welcoming atmosphere. You should feel comfortable from the moment you walk in.

Observe how the instructor interacts with students and how students interact with one another. If people are smiling, helping each other, and seem to enjoy what they are doing, that is a very good sign. If you leave your first class tired but happy, you have probably found the right place.

2. Don't be afraid to ask questions

Nobody expects you to know what is going on in your first few months. The learning curve is steep and full of small details. If something doesn't make sense, just ask about it.

Good instructors will always welcome questions, and most senior students will be happy to explain something if you are unsure. Asking for help shows that you are paying attention and that you want to improve. Everyone on the mat has been exactly where you are now.

3. Be patient

Progress in Jiu Jitsu is rarely quick. It comes slowly at first, and then you will often make a jump when you least expect it. There will be days when everything feels impossible, and others when everything starts to fall into place. Try not to judge yourself too harshly if it feels like things are not going well.

The bottom line is that consistency trumps talent. Keep showing up, keep listening, and let time do its work. Improvement often happens quietly in the background, then reveals itself when you look back months later.

4. Focus on the basics

The basics are the heart of Jiu Jitsu. They are the foundation upon which everything else is built. In your first few months, you do not need to chase advanced techniques or fancy moves. Just focus on understanding positions like guard, side control, mount, and back control.

Learn how to move efficiently, how to keep your balance, and how to defend yourself from common submissions. Every black belt, no matter how experienced, still drills these fundamentals.

5. Learn how to drill correctly

Drilling is where technique turns into instinct. It is not about rushing through the reps; it is about paying attention to the details.

Slow down. Feel how your body moves. Focus on timing, balance, and control rather than speed. Try to train with partners of different shapes, sizes, and abilities. Each person will give you a slightly different reaction, and that variation will make you better. Drilling well is not glamorous, but it is what separates people who improve from those who don't.

6. Stay safe

You can't train if you're injured, so take care of your body. Warm up properly before the class and stretch afterwards. If something hurts or does not feel right, it is best to stop. Tell your instructor and take a break if you need to.

There is a big difference between being tired and being hurt. Learn to recognise it. Jiu Jitsu is a long journey, and staying healthy is what allows you to enjoy it for years rather than months.

7. Don't be afraid to tap

Tapping is part of the process. It is how we learn safely. Everyone taps – even the best in the world. If your partner catches you in a submission, tap quickly and clearly. There is no shame in it.

Tapping protects your joints, keeps you safe, and allows both you and your training partners to keep learning. The sooner you accept that tapping is a normal part of Jiu Jitsu, the faster you will improve. Getting injured slows progress far more than getting submitted ever will.

8. Stay hydrated

You will sweat far more than you expect during Jiu Jitsu, especially in a busy class or during warm weather. Bring water or electrolyte-rich drinks to every session and

drink them before, during, and after training. Hydration helps your body function properly and your mind stay clear.

Even mild dehydration can affect your concentration and recovery. It is a small detail, but one that makes a big difference to how you feel on the mat.

9. Get plenty of rest

Recovery and progress occur when you rest, not during training. Sleep, time off, and good nutrition are all essential parts of your development. If you are run-down or sore, take a day off.

There is no prize for training through exhaustion. Listen to your body. The students who last the longest are the ones who balance effort with recovery. Consistency is what builds skill, not intensity alone.

10. Have fun

It is easy to take Jiu Jitsu too seriously (I certainly did at times!), especially when you start comparing yourself to others. Try not to and instead focus on enjoying the process. Laugh at your mistakes, celebrate small improvements, and appreciate the people you meet along the way.

Jiu Jitsu is one of the most challenging and rewarding things you can do. You will gain confidence, fitness, and a community of people who share the same passion. Whether your goal is self-defence, competition, or simply becoming a better version of yourself, you will find it all here.

So, tie your belt, step onto the mat, and begin. Every class you attend is a step forward, no matter how small it feels.

A Glossary of BJJ Terms

The terminology used in Brazilian Jiu Jitsu can be confusing for those new to the martial art. There are many technical terms and concepts that are unique to Jiu Jitsu, and it can be overwhelming to learn and remember them all. This glossary provides a list of commonly used terms in Jiu Jitsu to help those who are just starting out understand the language and concepts of Jiu Jitsu.

A

Americana – A submission hold that involves applying pressure to an opponent's shoulder joint by grasping their arm and rotating it outward, away from the body. The hold is also known as the "keylock" or "figure four armlock". The technique is also used in Judo, where it is known as ude garami.

Anaconda choke – A type of strangle where an opponent's arm is trapped with the head in a front headlock position. The attacker's arm is placed under the opponent's neck and connected to your bicep on the other arm in an arm-triangle.

Ankle lock – A type of submission hold that applies pressure to the ankle joint by extending the foot away from the body.

Armbar - A submission in which the attacker applies pressure to an opponent's elbow joint by grasping their arm and leveraging their body to force the arm to bend in an unnatural direction.

Arm drag – A technique that moves the opponent's arm across the body and out of the way. It can be used in various situations, for example, from standing to open up takedown attempts and from the guard to set up sweeps.

Arm-triangle choke – a type of strangle where the attacker uses the defender's own shoulder in combination with their forearm to apply pressure to the side of the

neck. Examples of variations of arm-triangle chokes include the anaconda and D'Arce chokes.

Ashi – The Japanese word for "leg" or "foot". It is often used in Jiu Jitsu terminology to refer to leg-based techniques or positions.

Ashi garami – The Japanese term for 'entangled limb' or 'entangled leg lock'. It originates from a Judo leg lock but is commonly used in Jiu Jitsu to refer to a position that controls the leg, from which various leg locks can be set up.

B

Back control – A position in which the practitioner controls their opponent from behind, usually by securing their waist and upper body with their arms and legs.

Back mount – Another position where the practitioner controls their opponent from behind. Back mount is often confused with back control, but in back mount, the defender is face down, lying prone. It is a very dominant position, often referred to as the worst position in Jiu Jitsu for the defender.

Backstep – A movement in which the practitioner takes a step backwards with one leg, usually to create distance or to reposition themselves.

Base – The foundation or stability of the body, usually achieved by maintaining a low centre of gravity and keeping the legs spread out widely when kneeling or standing.

Bear hug – A clinch in which the opponent wraps their arms around the practitioner's torso underneath the arms. Often used in an attempt to force an opponent to the ground.

Belt system – The coloured belt ranking system used in Jiu Jitsu to mark a student's progress and level of experience. The belt system starts with white and

progresses through blue, purple, brown, and finally black. Each belt signifies a certain level of skill and knowledge.

Berimbolo – A technique in which the practitioner spins under their opponent's legs and ends up behind them, often taking their back in the process.

Bicep slicer – A submission in which the practitioner attacks their opponent's bicep by driving their shin into the bicep muscle.

Bow and arrow choke – A powerful gi collar choke where the attacker grabs the opponent's collar and drags it across the neck to apply pressure. The defender is twisted into a curved bow shape, with the attacker moving to a 90-degree angle across the body, somewhat resembling a bow and arrow.

Breakfall – A technique used to safely fall to the ground. Primarily used to lessen the impact of the fall and prevent injury.

Butterfly guard – An open guard position in which the practitioner is in the seated position and hooks their feet behind their opponent's legs. These 'hooks' are used to control and elevate their opponent while looking for attacks and sweeps.

C

Calf slicer – A submission in which the practitioner attacks their opponent's leg by applying pressure to the calf muscle with the shin.

Cauliflower ear – An ear injury that occurs when the outer portion of the ear is struck, causing the dense connective tissue within the ear to separate from the underlying cartilage. Small blood vessels are situated in this area, and these proceed to bleed, causing the area to swell and become deformed. If left untreated, a large blood clot will form, deforming the cartilage portion of the ear.

Choke – A choke is a type of submission that works by applying pressure to the neck that restricts the flow through the trachea (windpipe).

Clinch – A standing position where both practitioners have some form of hold or grip on each other. It is usually used in an attempt, and to set up a takedown.

Closed guard – A type of guard where the person on the bottom (the guard player) has their legs wrapped around the waist of the person on the top (the passer) with their ankles closed together.

Collar choke – A type of choke that involves using the opponent's gi collar to apply pressure to the neck or throat. Although referred to as chokes, these are often actually strangles. (refer to 'strangle' definition below.)

Crank – A technique that applies pressure to the defender's spine. Cranks are considered dangerous and are illegal in many competition rulesets.

Crucifix position – A dominant position where the attacker is situated perpendicularly behind the opponent, chest against back, while controlling the opponent's arms. One of the opponent's arms is controlled using the legs, and the other using the arms, hence effectively putting the opponent in a position resembling a crucifix. If the opponent is wearing a gi, it allows for a collar strangle, often referred to as the crucifix choke.

D

D'Arce choke – A type of strangle that is very similar to the anaconda choke, but with the entry on the opposite side. It is named after the American grappler Joe D'Arce, who was famous for using the choke in competitions.

Deep half guard – An advanced guard position that is considered helpful against larger opponents because it can keep their weight off the bottom player. The guard player is situated underneath one of the legs of the opponent, with the leg on top of

one shoulder and the guard player's legs wrapped around the bottom of the top player's leg.

De La Riva guard – An open guard position where the guard player has one leg hooked around the opponent's leg, with the other leg extended out to the side. It is named after Ricardo De La Riva, who developed the guard position to counter guard passing attempts by larger, stronger grapplers.

Double leg takedown – A classic wrestling takedown where the attacker grabs both of their opponent's legs and takes them to the ground.

Double underhooks – A position where the practitioner has both of their opponent's arms underhooked and controlled. Often used to set up takedown attempts.

E

Escape – A technique used to free oneself from an opponent's control or submission hold.

Estima lock – A foot lock style submission that is mechanically similar to a toe hold. It was developed by two well-known competitors, the 'Estima brothers' – Victor and Braulio Estima.

Ezequiel choke – A type of choke/strangle that is set up by wrapping one arm under the opponent's head and then gripping the sleeve with the other hand to close the space and apply the submission. It was named after the Brazilian Olympic Judoka, Ezequiel Paraguassu, who was famous for submitting people with it.

F

Far side – The side of an opponent's body opposite from the side the practitioner is on.

Figure-four armlock – Another name used to describe the Americana.

Fireman's carry – A takedown technique where the practitioner drops down, lifts the opponent up, carries them over one shoulder and then somersaults, taking them to the ground.

Flow roll – A type of training that is similar mechanically to sparring, but the practitioners flow from one technique to another without stopping in a relaxed manner.

Foot lock – A broad term for submissions involving the opponent's foot, including ankle locks and toe holds.

G

Gable grip – A thumbless grip where the palms of the hand face each other. It is often used in clinches to set up takedowns and is named after the famous American freestyle wrestler Dan Gable.

Gi – The traditional uniform worn in Jiu Jitsu. The word 'gi' is derived from the Japanese term 'keikogi'. Roughly translated, 'keiko' means 'to practice', and 'gi' means 'clothing'. Sometimes the term 'dōgi' is used in Japan, which roughly translates as 'clothes of the way'.

Guard – Any position where the practitioner utilising the guard is on their back and has their legs either wrapped around their opponent or situated between themselves and their opponent. The legs are used to prevent the opponent from passing to a stronger position. There are numerous variations of the guard.

Guard pass – A technique used to move past an opponent's guard and gain a dominant position.

Guard retention – The act of maintaining control of one's own guard position or preventing an opponent from passing their guard.

Guillotine choke – A type of choke applied from in front of the opponent where the arms are encircled around the defender's neck in a similar manner to a guillotine.

H

Half guard – A guard position in which one player has one of the opponent's legs trapped between their own.

Head and arm choke – Another term used to describe the arm-triangle choke.

Headlock - A hold in which one player has their arm around their opponent's neck, either from the front or back.

Heel hook – An advanced level leg lock that involves twisting the foot using the heel as a lever in a way that twists and applies pressure to the knee joint.

Hip bump – A movement in which a player uses their hip to push or bump their opponent off balance. It is commonly used in the classic hip bump sweep.

Hip escape – A classic escape that uses the 'shrimping' motion to create space between the defender and the opponent and escape the top player's control.

Hook – A term used to describe the use of the feet to control the legs. Examples include the control of the inside of the thigh from the outside in back control and from the inside of the thighs in butterfly guard.

Honey hole – An advanced and highly dominant leg entanglement position. The defender's leg is pulled across the attacker's body, opening up the inside heel hook attack. It has several other names, including inside sankaku, the saddle and the 4-11.

I

IBJJF – The International Brazilian Jiu Jitsu Federation, the most well-known and recognised international governing body for Jiu Jitsu.

Imanari roll – A technique that involves rolling from a stand-up position into a leg lock entry. It is named after the famed mixed martial artist Masakazu Imanari.

Inside sankaku – Another name for the leg entanglement position, also known as the honey hole, the saddle and the 4-11.

Inverted guard – An open guard variation in which the guard player rolls upside down onto the top of their shoulders backwards to the opponent. It is often used for guard retention, but can also be used to enter into leg locks and other submissions.

J

Japanese necktie – A variation of the arm-triangle submission usually used against a turtled opponent. It is named after the famed Japanese mixed martial artist Shinya Aoki.

Judo – A martial art that originated in Japan and focuses on throws, take-downs, and ground control. Brazilian Jiu Jitsu originates from Judo and shares many techniques and principles with it.

Juji-gatame – A Japanese term that translates to ‘cross pin’ but is often used interchangeably with the straight or cross armbar submission.

K

Kesa gatame – A pin from side control commonly used in Judo. The top grappler has their hips switched, so they are facing towards the head of the bottom grappler while maintaining control of the nearside arm.

Kimono – another term for a 'gi' that is often used in Brazil.

Kimura lock - A submission that attacks the shoulder joint that utilises a figure-four grip and rotates the defender's arm backwards. It is known as gyaku ude-garami in Judo but is referred to as the Kimura in Jiu Jitsu, after the legendary Judoka Masahiko Kimura, who defeated Helio Gracie with the move in their famous challenge match. It is sometimes also referred to as the "double wristlock".

Kneebar – A leg lock submission that hyperextends the knee. The mechanics are similar to the armbar, but with the leverage directed through the knee joint instead.

Knee on belly – A dominant and highly effective position where the top grappler has their knee on the torso of the bottom grappler.

Knee shield – A guard position where the guard player has their shin across the opponent's chest and controls their posture, and creates space and distance with their own legs.

L

Lapel – The fabric on the collar of a gi jacket that can be used to grip and control the opponent.

Lasso guard – An open guard position where the guard player hooks one leg under the guard passer's arm (the lasso hook).

Leg drag – A guard passing position where the passer controls the guard player's hip by dragging the leg to one side.

Lion killer – Another name used for the rear-naked choke.

Lockdown – A variation of the half guard where the guard player locks their legs together, trapping and extending one of the top player's legs. It was popularised by Eddie Bravo, the founder of 10th Planet Jiu Jitsu.

Long step pass – A guard passing movement that involves the passer's leg stepping back to remove contact with the guard player's legs.

Loop choke – A type of strangle that utilises the defender's collar. The collar is grasped in one hand and pulled across the neck, while the attacker loops the hand to the opposite side around the neck and tightens the lapel.

M

Mata leão – Translates as 'lion killer' in Portuguese, another name used for the rear naked choke.

MMA (Mixed Martial Arts) – A full-contact combat sport that incorporates techniques from a variety of martial arts styles, including Brazilian Jiu Jitsu, wrestling, boxing and Muay Thai.

Mount – A dominant position where the top grappler is sat astride the opponent's torso, with their feet on the ground on either side of their body.

N

Neck crank – A type of technique that applies pressure to the cervical spine (neck) of the defender. Cranks are considered dangerous and are illegal in many competition rulesets.

No-gi - A style of Jiu Jitsu that is practised without the traditional gi. Instead, the practitioners wear rashguards and shorts.

North-south position – A variation of the side control position. The top grappler is lined up at roughly 180 degrees to the bottom player with their head pointing towards the feet.

O

Omoplata – A shoulder lock submission hold in which the attacker uses their legs to control their opponent's arm and apply pressure to the shoulder.

Open guard – Any guard position in which the legs are not wrapped around the opponent's body; instead, the legs are situated between the guard player and the passer.

Overhook – A type of grip in which one arm hooks over the top of the opponent's arm.

Over-under pass – A guard pass in which the attacker passes their opponent's legs by going over one of their legs and under their other leg with their arms.

P

Pass – To move past an opponent's guard or defence in order to achieve a more dominant position, such as side control or mount.

Peruvian necktie – A type of choke that is applied from the front headlock position. It is technically a choke but has elements of a neck crank. It is named after the famed Peruvian mixed martial artist Tony DeSouza.

Pull guard – To pull an opponent into the guard from the standing position.

Pummelling – The process of fighting for inside control on an opponent's arms or legs. Gaining inside control on the arms (double underhooks) is advantageous when attempting to take your opponent down from a standing position. Gaining inside control on the legs helps to set up leg attacks, such as ankle locks and heel hooks.

Q

Quarter guard – A last-ditch defensive guard that can be considered as lying halfway between half guard and mount. The bottom player only has their legs wrapped around the ankle of the top player.

R

Rear mount – Another term sometimes used to describe back control.

Rear-naked choke – A strangle in which the attacker's arm encircles the neck of the defender and then grabs their own bicep on the other arm. Also known as the lion killer and mata leão.

Reversal – Any movement that moves the bottom player to the top position that doesn't start in a guard position. Reversals from the guard are known as sweeps. Unlike sweeps, reversals do not score points in competition.

Rolling – A common term used for sparring or "live" training in Jiu Jitsu.

Rubber guard - A guard position that controls the passer's posture by clamping one of the legs over a shoulder and hooking the wrist around it. It was popularised and named by the no-gi grappling pioneer Eddie Bravo.

S

Side control – A dominant position where the person underneath is pinned with the top grappler perpendicular to them. The weight of the top grappler is applied to the opponent's chest.

Single leg takedown – A wrestling-style takedown in which the attacker takes their opponent to the ground by grabbing one of their legs and pulling it out from under them.

Strangle – A strangle is a type of submission that works by applying pressure to the sides of the neck that restricts the blood flow to the brain. Strangles result in unconsciousness if the defender does not tap out.

Submission - A submission is a technique that forces an opponent to tap out (signal submission by tapping the ground or their opponent). Common submissions in Jiu Jitsu include chokes, arm locks, and leg locks.

Sweep – A sweep is a technique where the practitioner on the bottom playing guard reverses the position and moves to the top. In contrast to reversals, sweeps must occur from a guard position and score points in competition.

T

Takedown – A technique where the attacker takes their opponent down to the ground. This can be achieved through various techniques, including Judo-style throws and trips, as well as wrestling-style takedowns.

Takedown defence – Techniques used to prevent an opponent from taking you down.

Tapping out – A signal, usually a tap on the opponent or the mat, that indicates a submission has been accepted.

Technical stand-up – An important self-defence technique that allows a practitioner to efficiently and effectively get back to their feet safely after being taken down by their opponent.

Toe hold – An advanced foot lock submission where the ankle and toes are controlled, and leverage is applied through the midtarsal joint in the centre of the foot.

Toreando pass – A speed-based guard pass that involves stepping around the opponent's legs in open guard and passing to the side. It has similarities to the movements of a matador misdirecting a bull, and is also known as the bullfighter pass.

Triangle choke – A submission that involves trapping the opponent's neck and one arm inside a triangle formed by your legs. The pressure applied to the sides of the neck restricts blood flow to the brain.

Turtle position – A defensive 'in-between' position that usually occurs after a defender has escaped from a more powerful position, such as mount or side mount. In the turtle position, the defender is on all fours, with their back rounded and their head tucked down towards their chest.

Twister – A rotational spinal crank submission that involves applying pressure to the neck and spine. The defender's head is forced towards one of their shoulders while the lower body is twisted to the opposite side.

U

Uchi mata – A classic Judo throw commonly used in Jiu Jitsu in which the attacker turns and throws the defender over their thigh. Considered the most spectacular of all the Judo throws.

Ude-garami – The Japanese term used to describe the Americana submission in Judo.

Uke - The Japanese term for a person receiving the technique or attack in a martial arts training drill or sparring match. Often used to describe the person that the instructor uses to demonstrate on.

Ukemi – The traditional Japanese martial arts term for breakfalling.

Underhook - A type of grip in which one arm hooks an opponent's arm.

Upa – The fundamental ‘bridge and roll’ mount escape, where the bottom player traps the arm and foot on one side and rolls the top player over, reversing the position.

V

Vale Tudo – A Brazilian martial art and combat sport that combines elements of various combat sports and martial arts, including Jiu Jitsu, boxing, and wrestling.

Von Flue choke - A submission used to counter a guillotine choke attempt. The defender moves to top-side control, underhooks the head, and locks their hands together, forming an arm-triangle type position.

W

Worm guard – An open guard position where the guard player wraps their lapel around the shin of the passer and then grips it with the far hand to control the leg. It was created and popularised by the famed competitor Keenan Cornelius.

Wristlock – A submission in which the attacker applies pressure to an opponent's wrist joint by controlling the elbow and knuckles.

X

X guard – An open guard position where the guard player is positioned underneath the passer's legs. The guard player's legs are hooked around one leg in an 'X' position with the other leg over their shoulder. It was popularised by the famed competitor Marcelo Garcia.

Y

Yudansha – The Japanese term for a person who holds the rank of black belt in Jiu Jitsu and other martial arts.

Z

Z guard – A variation of the knee shield guard where the guard player uses their bottom leg to hook the near leg and the knee of the upper leg to block the passer's hip and control their movement.

See You on the Mats

Writing this guide has been an absolute pleasure. It gave me the chance to look back to where it all began — those first few classes when I could barely keep up, when nothing seemed to work, and I honestly wondered if I would ever figure it out. It felt like such a struggle at the time. But looking back, it is funny how much Jiu Jitsu gives you without you even realising it. I had no idea then just how many positive changes it was already making in my life.

I never planned for it to become such a big part of my life. At the start, it was just a new hobby, something to balance out long shifts in the hospital. But somewhere along the line, it became something much more. It taught me patience when things weren't working, humility when they finally did, and the persistence to keep coming back no matter how the session went. And the friendships — those have been some of the best parts. Some of those have lasted nearly twenty years now.

Most of what I have written here simply comes from experience. I made plenty of mistakes, learning slowly, and occasionally got something right by accident. If a single thing in this book helps you settle into training, see something a bit differently, or just enjoy it more, then I am happy that it has done its job..

Wherever you are on your journey, just keep going. Some sessions will feel easy, others will leave you questioning what you are doing. Both matter. Both teach you something. Stay curious. Take care of the people you train with. And, above all, try to remember how lucky we are to have this in our lives.

Thanks so much for reading. I hope this gives you a bit of confidence, maybe a few ideas, and hopefully the same quiet love for Jiu Jitsu that's kept me on the mats all these years.

If anything here resonates with you, or you would like to share your own story, I would love to hear it. Please feel free to get in touch. You can find me through jiujitsubrotherhood.com or on our social pages.

Keep turning up. Appreciate the people you meet along the way. And remember, every black belt once started right where you are now.

See you on the mats,

Marc

About Marc

Marc Barton is a Brazilian Jiu Jitsu black belt, educator and former doctor with a background in human physiology and medicine. He holds a BSc in Physiology and an MBBS medical degree and spent over a decade working on the frontline in emergency and intensive care medicine.

Marc has trained in martial arts since childhood and also holds a black belt in Shotokan Karate. He began Brazilian Jiu Jitsu at the age of 30 and now teaches full time as the head instructor at Kingston Jiu Jitsu in London. His coaching blends scientific depth with real world experience, drawing from both his medical training and many years on the mat.

He focuses on helping adults build a sustainable and intelligent Jiu Jitsu practice, one that supports long term progress, joint health and technical development well into their 30s, 40s and beyond.

Marc's approach emphasises biomechanics, skill progression and thoughtful training habits over brute force. Through his teaching and writing, he aims to make Jiu Jitsu more accessible, effective and rewarding for anyone willing to show up and put in the work.

Marc teaches full time at Kingston Jiu Jitsu and contributes to Jiu Jitsu Brotherhood, where he writes about training, learning and longevity in the art.

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